

What Doesn't Settle

Book One of the Undiscovered Witch Series
Jessica Braden

PROLOGUE — What She Was For

Allison learned early that crying didn't make things better.

Emily cried like it was a language. Loud, sharp sounds that filled the house and demanded an answer. When Emily cried, doors opened. Voices rose. Someone always came running.

Allison sat on the third step from the bottom of the staircase and waited.

She was nine. Emily was four. Their mother was in the kitchen, their father somewhere down the hall. Allison could hear drawers opening too hard, the scrape of a chair leg against tile.

Emily's crying hit a higher pitch.

"I want it," Emily shouted. "I *want* it."

Allison didn't know what *it* was. That didn't seem important.

She knew what would happen next.

"Emily," their mother said, already tired. "We've talked about this."

Emily screamed again. Their father appeared in the doorway, rubbing his face, eyes unfocused like he'd been interrupted mid-thought.

Allison stood up.

She didn't hurry. She didn't sigh. She didn't say anything at all until she reached the kitchen.

"It's okay," Allison said quietly.

Everyone paused.

Her mother looked at her then—really looked, like she'd just noticed Allison was there.

"Sweetheart, you don't have to—"

"I can help," Allison said.

Emily was red-faced, fists clenched, shaking with feeling. Allison crouched in front of her.

“What’s wrong?” she asked.

Emily pointed at the cabinet. “The blue cup.”

The blue cup was in the dishwasher.

Allison stood, opened the dishwasher, and handed it to her.

The crying stopped so suddenly it felt less like comfort and more like relief settling into place.

Their mother exhaled. Their father laughed softly, relieved.

“See?” their mother said. “Your sister knows how to calm you down.”

Emily ran off with the cup, already distracted.

Allison stayed where she was.

“That was very mature,” her father said. “You’re such a good kid.”

Their mother smiled at her. “You always make things easier.”

Allison nodded.

She went back to the stairs and sat down again.

From there, she could hear Emily talking to herself in the living room, happily narrating a game no one else was playing. The house settled. The tension drained away.

Allison rested her chin on her knees.

She felt something then—not pride, exactly.

Something steadier.

Relief.

This was what she was for.

If she paid attention.

If she stayed calm.

If she didn’t need much.

The house stayed quiet, as if it had been waiting for her to decide that it would.

* * *

Chapter 1 — The Girl Who Fits Enough

The first thing Allison did every morning was check her phone.

Not because she was popular. Not because she expected a flood of messages. It was more like... habit. A reflex. The way you touch a bruise to see if it still hurts.

Notifications: three.

A weather alert. A reminder from the school app about attendance. And one from her Notes app, flagged because she'd starred it last night.

Don't forget: you're allowed to want things.

Allison stared at the line for a second, then locked her phone and rolled onto her back.

The ceiling above her was smooth except for one small crack near the corner—the kind that looked like a tiny lightning bolt. She'd stared at it so much she'd started to think she could map her moods by it. Some mornings it felt like a threat. Some mornings it was just... there.

Today it was just there.

She swung her legs over the side of the bed and listened.

The house was awake.

Not loudly—just enough. The sound of the coffee maker clicking. A cabinet door closing. The faint hum of the dryer in the laundry room downstairs.

And, from the hallway, Emily's music—thin through her closed door, as if she didn't want anyone to hear and also wanted everyone to hear.

Allison pulled on her favorite sweatshirt, the one that was soft in the sleeves from being washed too many times. It wasn't stylish. It wasn't ugly. It was safe.

Safe was most of her wardrobe.

She padded into the bathroom and looked at herself in the mirror.

Her hair was blonde and long, usually too long, the kind that slipped out of ponytails and tangled if you looked at it wrong. She'd never dyed it or cut it dramatically or done any of the things girls in movies did when they wanted to become a new version of themselves. Her eyes were green, a little too bright when the light hit them.

For a second—just a second—she caught herself looking like someone else.

Like a girl in a book jacket.

Then the thought slipped away and she was just Allison again.

Allison Crites.

The name looked normal on forms. The name sounded normal when teachers called roll. It didn't carry a story.

Survive. Blend. Don't make a scene.

It wasn't that she wanted to be invisible.

It was that she didn't want to be wrong.

Downstairs, her mom was at the counter with her back turned, hair clipped up, wearing the cardigan she wore when she had early meetings.

"Morning," Allison said.

Her mom turned. "Hey, honey."

Her smile landed soft and practiced, like she was laying something carefully on a shelf.

Allison opened the fridge. Milk. Leftovers. A box of strawberries that looked like they were on their last day.

"Did you sleep?" her mom asked.

"Yeah."

"Good."

Allison grabbed a yogurt and a spoon and sat at the table.

Her dad came in a minute later, already in his work jacket, keys in hand, eyes flicking to the clock.

“Morning, kiddo,” he said, kissing the top of her head as he passed.

Kiddo.

Not Allison. Not honey. Not sweetheart. Kiddo was what you called someone when you didn’t want to get too specific.

Emily came down a few minutes later like a firework.

She didn’t walk so much as appear—hair messy, pajama pants loud, phone in hand, already talking as if she’d been mid-conversation since midnight.

“Mom, I need the purple hoodie. The one that makes my eyes look good. The gray one makes me look like—like a sad Victorian child.”

Her mom laughed. Real laughter, the kind that showed teeth. “It’s in the dryer. If you’d stop leaving clothes on the floor, you’d know where things were.”

Emily spun dramatically toward Allison. “Did you hear that? She’s attacking me. In the morning.”

Allison lifted her spoon. “I’m witnessing.”

Emily grinned, slid into the chair next to her, and stole one of Allison’s strawberries without asking. Allison didn’t stop her.

Emily was fourteen and somehow made every room feel like it was built for her. She had dark hair that fell in perfect waves like it had a personal assistant. She had her mother’s confidence and her father’s ability to move like the world expected her to. She was loud in a way

that read as charming instead of annoying.
If Allison had been a different kind of person, she would've hated her.

Sometimes she tried to.

But mostly she just watched her like someone watching a show they weren't allowed to be in.

"Are you coming to my game Friday?" Emily asked, already chewing.

"Allison has work," her mom said immediately.

Allison paused.

"I—" she started, but her mom kept going.

"The school store needs her. She's responsible."

Emily rolled her eyes. "Of course. Allison is responsible. Allison is always responsible.

Allison should get a trophy for being so responsible."

The words weren't mean, exactly.

But they landed like a label.

Responsible: the version of Allison people could explain.

Allison swallowed. "I can probably come after."

Emily brightened. "Really?"

Allison's dad glanced over. "If you're not too tired."

Allison nodded, even though she hadn't been asked a question.

She looked down at her yogurt, suddenly not hungry.

Something about mornings always made her feel like she was watching other people's lives happen around her. Like everyone else had a script and she was improvising, hoping no one noticed the hesitation.

The hallway smelled like floor cleaner and too many different perfumes layered on top of each other.

Allison moved through it the way she always did—shoulders slightly tucked in, eyes forward but unfocused, aware without appearing to be. She preferred being unnoticed. She paused near the guidance office, leaning her shoulder against the wall where the noise dimmed just enough to breathe.

She pulled out her phone and opened Notes.

| okay.

| i'm writing this here because i don't know where else to put it.

|

| that feels dramatic already, which is annoying, because i'm not trying to be dramatic. i just... need somewhere that isn't my head. everything sounds louder in my head lately, like my thoughts are echoing off each other and i can't tell which one came first.

|

| if anyone ever read this, they'd probably think i was lonely.

| which i guess i am.

| but not in the way people usually mean.

|

| i'm around people all the time.

|

| that's kind of the problem.

|

| school is full. the hallways are loud. people talk to me. teachers like me. i sit with people at lunch. i don't eat alone in bathrooms or anything like that. i'm not invisible.

|

| but i don't feel... placed.

|

| like everyone else is standing on solid ground
and i'm balancing on the edge of something,
pretending i'm not scared of falling.

| i don't know when this started.

| maybe it's always been there and i just got old
enough to notice.

| or maybe senior year just makes everything feel
heavier, like there's a timer running down and
everyone else knows what happens when it hits
zero except me.

| i keep thinking about moments. little ones.
things that shouldn't matter.

| like when i sit down next to someone who looks
tense and a few minutes later they aren't
anymore. or when a conversation feels like it's
about to turn sharp and then it just... doesn't. like
the air changes its mind.

| that sounds fake when i write it out. like i'm
trying to give myself credit for something.

| i'm not. i swear.

| if anything, it makes me uncomfortable.

| because i don't remember doing anything.

| i don't say the right thing on purpose. i don't
plan it. i don't even want to be involved half the
time. i just want things to calm down so i can
breathe again.

|
| is that bad?

|
| wanting things to stop?

|
| i don't think it should be.

|
| but sometimes when it happens, i get this weird
feeling in my chest. not good, not bad. just... like
something clicked into place that wasn't there
before.

|
| and then i think about it too much and
everything feels wrong.

|
| maybe i'm just sensitive.

|
| people say that like it's a compliment, but it
never feels like one. it feels like another way of
saying too much. too aware. too quiet. too
careful.

|
| i've always been careful.

|
| careful not to say the wrong thing.

| careful not to take up too much space.

| careful not to make things harder for anyone
else.

|
| i don't know when i decided that was my job.

|
| sometimes i wonder if everyone else has these
thoughts and they're just better at ignoring them.

|
| or maybe they don't need to write them down
because they trust themselves.

| i don't.

| that's the part i don't like admitting.

| i don't trust my own head anymore.

| things feel slippery lately. like if i don't grab onto the thought right away, it changes shape or disappears completely. writing it here makes it feel more real. more contained.

| like putting something in a box and labeling it so it doesn't move around when you're not looking.

| i guess this is my box.

| if you're real—

| and i know you're not, but if you were—

| i'd tell you that i don't want to be special. i don't want to stand out. i don't want attention.

| i just want to understand why i feel different even when no one is treating me differently.

| i want to know why being around people makes me feel more alone instead of less.

| i want to know why i feel relieved when things quiet down, and why that relief sometimes feels like guilt afterward.

| that's the part that scares me.

| because what if wanting quiet isn't the same as wanting peace?

| what if wanting things to stop means something
else entirely?

| no. that's too far.
| ignore that.

| see, this is why i'm writing. because my
thoughts run ahead of me and then look back like
are you coming or not and i don't know how to
answer.

| if i don't write this down, i'll convince myself
tomorrow that none of this mattered. that i was
just tired. that i was being dramatic. that everyone
feels this way and i'm just bad at handling it.

| and maybe that's true.

| but if it is, i want proof.

| so here it is.

| i feel out of place even when i'm exactly where
i'm supposed to be.

| i feel like i'm holding something fragile inside
me, and i don't know what happens if i drop it.

| i don't know if writing this helps.

| but it feels like breathing.

| and right now, that's enough.

| — later

| i reread this and now i'm embarrassed.

| god, i sound ridiculous.

| if someone found this—if kara saw it, or worse,
if mom did—it would confirm every quiet fear i
have about myself.

| dramatic. self-centered. making problems out of
nothing.

| i almost deleted all of it.

| my thumb was literally on “select all.”

| i didn't do it.

| because what if deleting it doesn't make it go
away?

| what if the problem isn't that i'm writing this
down

| but that it's happening at all?

| that thought makes my stomach hurt.

| i added one more thing because i couldn't not
say it:

| i'm scared that if i stop paying attention,
something bad will happen

| and it will be my fault for not noticing it sooner.

| that feels true in a way i don't like.

| i don't think i'm powerful.

| i think i might be responsible.

| and responsibility is something i understand.

| that makes this scarier, not less.

| i'm putting my phone face-down now because i
don't want to look at this anymore.

| i don't know what it means that i didn't delete it.

| but it scares me.

| end.

Allison locked her phone and slid it back into her pocket. The hallway noise rushed back in, too loud after the quiet she'd made for herself.

She pushed off the wall and kept walking.

Kara didn't say anything when Allison sat down at lunch.

That was one of the reasons Allison liked her.

The cafeteria was already loud—chairs scraping, voices overlapping, someone laughing too hard at something that wasn't funny. Allison slid into the seat across from Kara, setting her tray down carefully like noise might spill out if she wasn't gentle.

Kara was halfway through a carton of chocolate milk, eyes fixed on her phone. She glanced up, lifted her chin in a brief acknowledgment, then went back to whatever she was reading.

No questions.

No pressure.

They ate in silence.

Allison watched the room instead.
She felt like she was behind glass.
A raised voice near the exit snagged her attention.
Please don't, she thought.
The argument fizzled out almost immediately.
Coincidence.
Her heart kept racing.
Kara slid a doodled napkin toward her.
"For you," she said. "It's supposed to be a dragon
but I panicked."
Allison smiled and folded it carefully, tucking it
into her pocket.
The bell rang.
They walked to class together, shoulder to
shoulder in the crowd.
Allison wasn't alone.
And she still felt completely, terrifyingly isolated.
The hallway felt louder after lunch.
Not in a way anyone else would have
noticed—just sharper at the edges, like sounds
had gained teeth. Allison walked with Kara
partway, then peeled off toward her next class.
She didn't slow down until she reached the
stairwell.
The air there was cooler, the concrete walls
muting the noise into something manageable. She
rested her hand against the railing.
A group of students crowded the landing above
her, voices overlapping.
Allison took the first step up.
Someone laughed—too sharp. Someone else
snapped back.
Her foot paused mid-step.
She didn't want to be here.
She didn't want to feel the pressure blooming
behind her eyes.

Please don't, she thought.
The voices cut off abruptly.
Allison froze.
For a heartbeat, the stairwell was completely
silent.
Then one of the students scoffed and walked
away.
Allison's pulse roared.
By the time she reached class, her hands were
shaking.
Dinner was spaghetti.
Emily talked nonstop.
Allison listened.
"You're quiet," Emily said.
"Just tired," Allison replied.
Her mom nodded and turned back to Emily.
After dinner, Allison retreated to her room.
She lay on her bed and stared at the ceiling crack.
Later, when the house was quiet, Allison opened
Notes again.
| new rule.
|
| don't think things when you're scared.
|
| fear feels too much like permission.
|
| i don't know what happens if i want the wrong
thing.
Allison locked her phone and set it down.
She curled under the blanket.
She didn't know what she was.
But she knew this wasn't going to stop.
* * *

Chapter 2 — Things That Go Smoothly

The worst part was that nothing felt dramatic. If Allison had woken up with a headache, or a sense of dread, or even that hollow, buzzing feeling she sometimes got before exams, she would have trusted it more. Those sensations came with explanations attached—stress, nerves, lack of sleep.

But she woke up feeling... fine.

Not rested. Not energized.

Just fine, in a way that felt strangely undeserved. She lay still for a moment, staring at the familiar crack in the ceiling. It branched near one corner like it had once considered going somewhere else and changed its mind. She'd stared at it long enough over the years that it felt like a marker for time, proof that things could stay the same even when everything else shifted around them.

The house sounded normal.

Emily's voice floated down the hallway, fast and animated, like she'd already started living the day before anyone else was fully awake. Downstairs, the coffee maker hissed and clicked. A cabinet closed. Footsteps crossed the kitchen.

Allison waited for the unease from yesterday to rush back all at once.

It didn't.

That bothered her more than she wanted to admit. She dressed on autopilot, pulling on clean jeans and a soft sweater she'd worn often enough that it no longer required thought. As she brushed her hair, she checked her reflection only long enough to confirm she looked acceptable—presentable, forgettable, the kind of person teachers nodded at

approvingly without remembering later.
She told herself yesterday had been a fluke.
People argued all the time. Teachers forgot
students. Bells rang late. None of it meant
anything unless you decided it did, and she'd
always been careful not to decide things like that.
Breakfast passed the way it usually did: half
conversations, overlapping schedules, Emily
narrating something Allison only half-followed.
Allison answered when spoken to, smiled when
expected, and kept her thoughts deliberately
unremarkable.

She didn't mention the stairwell.

She didn't mention the feeling.

There was nothing to mention.

Outside, the air had that early-morning chill that
made everything feel briefly sharper and cleaner
than it really was. The walk to school was
uneventful. Cars passed. Someone waved at
someone else. A dog barked behind a fence.
Normal.

The parking lot buzzed with engines and laughter.
Groups clustered near the entrance, phones
already out, faces angled toward invisible
audiences. Allison walked past them with the
familiar relief of not belonging to any one circle
strongly enough to be missed.

She told herself she liked it that way.

First period was English.

She slid into her seat just as the bell finished
ringing and opened her notebook to a blank page.
The room smelled faintly of dry erase markers
and too much perfume. Sunlight filtered through
the tall windows, catching dust in the air.

Mrs. Harlan stood at the front, flipping through
papers.

“Okay,” she said, clapping her hands once. “Cold reads today.”

A collective groan rippled through the room. Allison felt the familiar tightening in her chest—not panic, just awareness. Cold reads weren’t hard. She read well. Teachers had told her that. But there was something about hearing her own voice fill the room without warning that made her acutely conscious of herself in a way she didn’t enjoy.

She lowered her gaze to the page and traced the margin absently with her pen.

Please don’t call on me, she thought.

The thought barely registered. It was automatic, unexamined, the same way her shoulders tensed when something loud went off nearby.

Mrs. Harlan began calling names from the front row, moving steadily down the seating chart.

Allison listened without really listening, letting the cadence of other voices wash over her. Pages turned. Someone stumbled over a sentence and laughed nervously. Mrs. Harlan corrected pronunciation gently and moved on.

It wasn’t until the reading ended that Allison looked up.

Her name was still untouched.

She frowned.

Mrs. Harlan was already collecting papers, the moment clearly over. Chairs creaked as students shifted. Conversation returned in low murmurs.

Allison flipped through her notes, searching for an explanation. Had she missed something? Had the seating chart changed? Had she spaced out at exactly the wrong moment?

She hadn’t.

The realization arrived late and cold.

That was my turn.

She waited for the correction that never came.

The moment passed.

By the time the bell rang, the relief she expected hadn't shown up. Instead, something colder settled in her chest, like she'd stepped onto solid ground that hadn't been there a second before.

Second period was biology.

Group lab day.

Allison slid onto a stool and scanned the room automatically, noting who was already paired off and who wasn't. She did this every time without thinking, the way you checked traffic before crossing a street.

Her stomach dipped when she saw who was still standing alone.

He wasn't a bad person. He just didn't understand the invisible rules everyone else followed instinctively.

Anyone but him, Allison thought.

The thought came sharper this time.

She felt bad for it immediately.

She wasn't cruel. She wasn't even unkind. She would have worked with him if she had to. She always did what she was supposed to do.

Mrs. Grant clapped her hands. "Okay, looks like we've got one extra today. Let's shuffle just a bit."

A girl at the next table groaned. "Seriously? We already set up."

"Just one swap," Mrs. Grant said cheerfully.

"You'll live."

She pointed across the room. "You—go join them. And you—switch places."

The awkward boy blinked, startled, then gathered his things and shuffled toward the other table.

Someone else slid into the empty seat beside Allison instead.

The movement was quick. Efficient. Over.

Allison stared down at the lab equipment, ears ringing softly.

Relief came first.

Then guilt, hot and immediate.

She hadn't done anything. She hadn't said a word. It could have happened regardless of what she'd thought.

And yet the timing clung to her.

By the time the bell rang, the feeling hadn't gone away.

Third period history blurred past in a haze of dates and names. Allison checked the clock as she rounded the corner near the science wing.

Two minutes.

She knew she was going to be late.

Not disastrously late. Just enough to draw attention.

Just this once, she thought, breathless as she took the stairs two at a time.

She pushed through the classroom door.

No bell.

Mr. Alvarez was still shuffling papers. Students were talking. Someone laughed.

Allison slid into her seat, pulse loud in her ears.

The bell rang thirty seconds later.

Relief came—and then unease followed close behind it.

Between classes, the hallway felt clogged, bodies moving in uneven clumps. Allison nearly ran into someone at the corner and apologized automatically. She reached her locker and leaned back against the cool metal, trying to breathe evenly.

Nothing is happening, she told herself.

Fourth period was math.

She noticed herself almost thinking please don't call on me and stopped the thought before it finished forming. She stared hard at her notebook, as if concentration could pin her thoughts in place.

Mr. Jacobs scanned the room and called on students.

Not her.

She didn't feel relieved.

She felt watched—by herself.

Lunch was louder than she expected.

She found Kara at their usual table and slid into the seat across from her. Kara talked easily, complained about a quiz, laughed at something someone else said. Allison laughed in the right places, nodded at the right times.

Normal.

Except the weight of everything she wasn't saying pressed harder with each passing minute. She considered telling Kara. Imagined starting with a joke. Imagined Kara laughing, or worrying.

She said nothing.

After school, Allison didn't go straight home. She turned toward the narrow path behind the houses and followed it to the creek. The water moved steadily over smooth stones, indifferent and constant. She sat and watched it, hugging her knees.

She didn't wish.

She didn't think anything on purpose.

She just let the thoughts come and go until the light shifted and the air grew colder.

Then she went home.

She went to her room.
She opened her phone.

* * *

| i keep opening this and then closing it again.

| i don't know why i'm so convinced that writing
this down makes it worse.

| or maybe that it makes it real.

| nothing actually happened today.

| i need to say that first.

| i wasn't called on.

| i didn't get paired with someone awkward.

| i wasn't late.

| those are normal things.

| those things happen all the time.

| i know that.

| i just can't stop replaying the timing.

| not the events themselves.

| the space right before them.

| i didn't make wishes.

| that sounds ridiculous.

| i had thoughts.

| the kind you barely notice.

| the kind everyone has.

| if i hadn't been paying attention because of
yesterday, i wouldn't even be writing this.

| maybe the problem is me.

| i had lunch with kara like always.

| she was normal.

| i was normal.

| except i felt like i was holding something back
the entire time.

| i don't want to be dramatic.

| or paranoid.

| or special.

| i want this to be nothing.

| but pretending i didn't notice feels dishonest.

| and noticing feels dangerous.

* * *

Chapter 3 — The Shape of Consequences

Allison was already tired when she woke up. Not the heavy kind of tired that came from staying up late, not the one that had a clear cause you could point to and blame. This was the thin, brittle kind that lived in the edges of her day—where sounds felt sharper, where people's voices had corners, where her own thoughts landed with more weight than they should.

Emily's alarm went off once. Then again.

Allison stared at the ceiling and waited for Emily to hit snooze a third time, because Emily always did. It was practically a ritual. A pattern. The thought made Allison's stomach tighten in a way that felt unfair to both of them.

She rolled onto her side and checked the time on her phone.

She didn't open her notes.

The notes app sat there like an open door in her head, and Allison wasn't sure she could step through it and come back out again like a normal person. She wasn't sure she wanted to.

She put the phone down and lay still for another minute, trying to make herself breathe like she hadn't been counting her thoughts for the last two days.

Downstairs, the coffee maker clicked and hissed.

A cabinet closed with a little too much force.

Someone—her dad, probably—cleared his throat like he was trying to wake up the house with sound.

Allison got up.

She dressed on autopilot, pulling on jeans and a sweater without looking too closely at herself.

Her hair felt heavy, like it was still holding sleep. When she brushed it, she watched the mirror just long enough to make sure her face looked neutral. Fine. Normal. The kind of normal that didn't ask questions.

In the hallway, Emily's door cracked open and a bright sliver of light spilled out. Emily appeared in the doorway with her phone already in hand, hair messy in a way that somehow looked intentional anyway.

"You're up," Emily said, like this was surprising. Allison nodded. "I have school."

Emily smirked. "Oh right. That thing."

Allison didn't answer.

Downstairs, breakfast passed the way it usually did.

Emily talked, voice fast and certain, as if she'd already decided what kind of day it was going to be. Their mom moved around the kitchen with the quiet efficiency of someone who was always five minutes behind schedule. Their dad read something on his phone, thumb scrolling, eyes unfocused.

Allison ate her cereal slowly, listening to the clink of spoons and the hum of the refrigerator.

"You're quiet," her mom said, not looking up.

Allison shrugged. "Just tired."

Her mom's gaze flicked to her, brief and searching, then away again. "Late night?"

"No."

"Okay," her mom said, like she'd offered a door and Allison had chosen not to go through it.

Emily laughed at something on her screen, loud enough that Allison's shoulders tightened.

Allison hated that her body reacted like that. She hated that she could feel herself bracing for her

own family.

Her dad finally looked up. “You got everything for today?”

“Yeah,” Allison said. “Homework, binder, everything.”

“Good,” he said, and went back to his phone.

Allison stared at her bowl. The cereal had gone soggy.

She told herself she was being dramatic.

She told herself that middle-of-the-road girls didn’t get to be dramatic. They didn’t get to be interesting. They got to be functional.

She finished breakfast, rinsed her bowl, and left before anyone could ask anything else.

Outside, the air was cold enough to wake her up properly. The kind of cold that made your lungs sting for a second when you breathed in too fast.

The sky was pale, washed-out blue, like the day hadn’t decided what color it wanted to be yet.

The walk to school was ordinary—cars passing, someone jogging with headphones, a dog barking behind a fence.

But Allison felt like she was walking with something invisible tucked under her coat.

At school, the parking lot buzzed with the familiar morning energy—engines, laughter, shouting, the sound of teenagers trying to outrun their own lives for a few minutes.

Allison moved through it like she always did: head up, face neutral, eyes not lingering too long on anyone. She was good at being present without being noticed.

The hallway smelled like floor cleaner and cheap body spray. Lockers slammed. Someone argued with someone else about a test they hadn’t studied for. A teacher stood near the office,

already tired.

Allison went to her locker, spun the dial, and swapped books with hands that felt slightly clumsy. She told herself she was just tired.

It was fine.

It was all fine.

The hallway near the science wing always felt tighter than the others.

Not physically—there was enough space—but something about the way lockers jutted out unevenly, the way people stopped abruptly to talk, made it feel like you were always navigating around someone else's urgency. Allison slowed instinctively, adjusting her grip on her bag. She caught herself thinking about nothing in particular.

That scared her a little.

Lately, nothing felt too open. Too quiet. Like space that invited her thoughts to stretch out farther than she wanted them to.

She focused on the sound of her shoes against the floor. On the hum of voices. On the simple act of walking forward.

Someone brushed past her shoulder without apologizing.

Allison flinched and told herself not to take it personally.

The moment happened between classes.

She didn't know that at first, of course. No one ever knows when the moment is happening. It always looks like nothing until it's already past. Allison was halfway down the hallway near the science wing when she heard the sound—sharp clatter, a hard impact, the kind that makes a dozen people react without meaning to.

A backpack hit the floor.

A binder popped open.

Papers spilled like confetti, sliding across the tile and under shoes.

Allison stopped.

Rachel was on the ground.

Not sprawled, not dramatically, but kneeling awkwardly with one hand braced against the floor and the other reaching for a sheet of paper that had already skated out of reach. Her hair was hanging in her face. Her cheeks were bright red in the way that happens instantly, like embarrassment flips a switch inside the skin.

People slowed.

Not to help. Not right away.

They slowed to look.

A couple of kids laughed—not even loudly, not the cruel movie-villain laugh Allison might have been able to categorize and hate easily. This was casual laughter. Bored laughter. The kind people made when they didn't think it counted.

Rachel made a small sound, not quite a word. She shoved hair behind her ear and reached again for her papers, movements too fast, too frantic.

Someone stepped on a worksheet without noticing.

Someone else muttered, "Oof," like they were watching a blooper reel.

Phones appeared.

Not all at once. Not dramatically. One student angled their screen downward, pretending to text while recording anyway. Another lifted their phone a little higher, then lowered it quickly when a teacher's voice called from somewhere farther down the hall.

Allison stood there with her bag heavy on her shoulder.

She could step forward.

She could kneel down. She could pick up papers.

She could say something—anything—that might rupture the moment and give Rachel a way out of it.

She didn't.

It was only a second.

Maybe less.

But in that second, Allison felt everything at once: the heat in her face, the tightness in her chest, the awareness that everyone was watching, and the terrifying possibility that if she stepped in, they would watch her too.

She told herself she was frozen because she didn't know what to do.

She told herself that later.

In the moment, it was simpler and uglier:

She didn't want to be seen.

Rachel grabbed her binder, shoved loose papers into it without sorting them, hands shaking. She looked up once—only once—and Allison caught a glimpse of her eyes.

Not angry.

Not accusing.

Just wide. Humiliated. Trying not to cry.

Allison's stomach dropped.

A teacher's voice cut through the hallway like a blade. "Let's move it, people."

The crowd broke apart immediately.

Phones vanished. Laughter turned into murmurs.

The flow of students resumed like water moving around a rock.

Rachel stood up fast, clutching her binder to her chest, and walked away without looking at anyone again.

Allison moved too.

The rest of the hallway passed in a blur.
Allison reached her classroom without remembering how. She sat down without remembering pulling the chair out. When she opened her notebook, she stared at the page for a full minute before realizing it was upside down. Her body felt hollow.
Like everything inside her had shifted slightly out of alignment and never quite snapped back. She kept waiting for a feeling to arrive—panic, anger, grief, something that would make sense. Nothing did.
That was worse.
The question followed her into class.
Why didn't I do anything?
In history, Mr. Alvarez's voice washed over her in facts and dates Allison couldn't hold onto. She wrote notes anyway, pen moving on habit, her page filling with neat lines that meant nothing. Every few minutes, her mind snapped back to the hallway.
Rachel's hands.
The paper sliding under someone's shoe.
The sound of laughter that barely even tried to be cruel.
And her own stillness.
The bell rang and Allison flinched like she'd been caught doing something wrong.
The hallway between classes felt too narrow. Too loud. Too close. Allison kept her eyes down and moved fast, like speed could erase the last hour. By lunch, the story had already spread.
Allison saw it in the way people clustered in groups, heads angled toward each other, phones held in hands but not always used. She caught a glimpse of a screen as she passed—Rachel's hair

in her face, the moment frozen mid-motion. Allison looked away so quickly her neck twinged. She found Kara at their usual table near the windows. Kara was talking animatedly, eyebrows drawn together, one hand slicing the air as she made a point.

When Kara saw Allison, she paused, then patted the seat beside her.

Allison slid into it, tray balanced carefully, like her hands needed something to do.

Kara leaned in. "Did you see what happened to Rachel?"

Allison swallowed. "Yeah."

"That was brutal," Kara said, voice low but intense. "Someone recorded it. It's everywhere."

Allison stared at her food. Her appetite had disappeared somewhere between history and the cafeteria line.

"People are awful," Allison said, and hated how thin her voice sounded.

Kara exhaled. "I feel bad for her. Like—she didn't do anything. She literally tripped. And now everyone gets to make it a thing."

Allison nodded.

Kara's anger made sense.

It had edges. Direction. A target.

Allison watched Kara talk, watched the way her hands moved when she was frustrated, and felt strangely disconnected from it all, like she was observing a reaction she'd missed the instructions for.

Kara could be mad for Rachel.

Allison couldn't stop being mad at herself.

Part of Allison wanted Kara to stay mad longer.

To push harder. To make it matter.

And then Allison hated herself for that too.

Because Rachel was the one who had been on the floor. Rachel was the one whose face people were replaying on their phones.

Allison wasn't allowed to want anything here.

Kara kept talking, but the conversation drifted, the way lunch conversations always did.

Someone mentioned a teacher. Someone complained about a homework assignment. Kara laughed at a joke and the sound felt wrong in Allison's ears, like laughter didn't belong in a day that had already been cut open.

Allison tried to stay present. She nodded. She smiled. She made herself swallow bites of food she couldn't taste.

But she kept seeing Rachel's eyes.

When lunch ended, Kara stood and bumped

Allison's shoulder lightly. "You good?"

Allison forced a smile. "Yeah. Just tired."

Kara gave her a look that lingered half a second longer than usual, then shrugged. "Okay. See you later."

Allison watched her disappear into the crowd and felt the absence like pressure.

The rest of the day moved strangely.

Not in a dramatic way. Not with sudden lightning strikes or teachers shouting or the universe announcing itself.

It moved in the subtle way a room feels different after someone has slammed a door.

In math, Allison stared at the board and realized she couldn't remember what she'd just read. In biology, she copied answers from the worksheet without understanding them. In English, she wrote down a quote the teacher said would "probably be on the test" and then immediately forgot it.

Every time she looked at someone's phone, her stomach tightened.

Every time she heard someone laugh, she wondered if they were laughing at Rachel.

Or if they were laughing at nothing at all, because the world didn't keep score the way Allison did.

The thought came late, when Allison finally had a moment alone.

It wasn't sharp.

It wasn't even fully formed.

It came from guilt and helplessness and the sick feeling of replaying the hallway moment over and over without being able to change it.

I wish people would just leave her alone.

The thought slipped through her mind like breath.

Allison felt it and immediately tried to take it back—not because it was cruel, but because it felt like reaching for something she didn't deserve.

She hadn't helped Rachel on the floor.

She didn't get to want anything now.

She shoved the thought down and moved on with her day, pretending it hadn't happened.

By the end of school, the energy in the hallways had shifted.

Not louder. Not quieter.

Just different.

Allison saw it in the way people talked with less excitement, in the way phones stayed down longer, in the way the story seemed to have lost its shine.

By the time she reached her locker, someone behind her said, "It got taken down."

Another voice replied, "Probably reported."

Someone else scoffed. "It wasn't even that bad anyway."

Allison's hands went cold.

She turned her head slightly, pretending to look for a book, and listened without looking.
They were talking about Rachel.
About the video.
About the thing that had made her stomach twist all day.
It was gone.
Just gone.
The relief didn't fade right away.
That terrified her.
She walked the length of the hallway carrying it like contraband, afraid someone might notice it on her face. Afraid she'd smile at the wrong moment. Afraid relief would turn into gratitude if she wasn't careful.
She tried to make herself feel worse.
She replayed the fall again. Rachel's hands. The laughter. The phones.
It didn't undo the relief.
It just layered guilt on top of it.
Allison left school fast.
She didn't wait for Kara. She didn't linger near the front entrance. She didn't stop at her locker twice like she sometimes did when she forgot something.
She just walked.
Her feet carried her toward home without thinking, until she realized she wasn't on the main road.
She'd turned down the narrower path behind the houses without deciding to.
The creek waited at the edge of town like it always did, water moving steadily over stones, indifferent and constant.
Allison dropped her backpack and sat hard on the bank, hugging her knees.

She tried to breathe the way she usually did here.
In through her nose.

Out through her mouth.

She counted the seconds without meaning to.

The water didn't help.

The rhythm didn't sink in.

Her chest stayed tight, breath shallow and uneven.

She dug her fingers into the dirt beside her,
grounding herself in something real. Cold soil
packed under her nails.

It didn't fix anything.

The creek had always been where things settled.

Today, nothing settled.

"I should've done something," Allison said aloud,
and the words sounded strange in the open air.

She stared at the current and tried to replay the
moment again in a way that ended differently.

If she stepped forward.

If she picked up papers.

If she said, "Hey, it's fine," in a voice loud
enough for people to hear.

If she glared at the kids with phones.

If she was brave.

If she wasn't herself.

Allison exhaled slowly.

She picked up a stone and rolled it between her
fingers, feeling the damp grit against her skin.

Then she tossed it into the water. It disappeared
with a small plunk, ripples spreading outward and
then fading.

Nothing dramatic.

Just movement.

She wanted to tell herself that was what today had
been.

A ripple. A moment. Something that would fade.

But the memory didn't feel like it was fading. It
felt like it was taking root.
What scared her wasn't just that she hadn't acted.
It was that she'd noticed herself not acting.
That she'd watched herself hesitate and
recognized it as a choice.
That she'd known she was choosing safety over
kindness and couldn't stop herself.
And then later, when the video disappeared, she'd
felt relief like she'd earned it.
Allison pressed her palms into her knees.
If my thoughts matter, she whispered, and
stopped.
The words felt too big, too ridiculous, too close to
something she wasn't ready to say.
She tried again, quieter.
If my thoughts... do anything...
The air swallowed the sentence.
She stared at the water until her eyes hurt.
What if it was coincidence?
What if she was doing the thing she
feared—turning ordinary patterns into stories
because she wanted to believe she mattered?
But what if it wasn't?
What if her silence mattered too?
The thought turned her stomach.
Because silence was her whole life.
Silence at breakfast while Emily talked.
Silence in class unless called on.
Silence in hallways while other people took up
space.
Silence while Rachel's papers scattered on the
floor.
Silence was how she survived.
If silence was suddenly a choice, if it suddenly
carried weight... then what did that make her?

She sat at the creek until the light shifted and the cold seeped through her jeans. The water kept moving, unconcerned. Leaves drifted past, caught briefly on stones and then released again.

Allison wished she could be like that.

Drift past.

Get released.

Not stick.

Eventually, she stood, shoulders stiff, and slung her backpack on. The walk home felt longer than it should have, as if the air itself had thickened.

At home, the house felt too normal.

Emily's voice floated from somewhere. A door opened and closed. The smell of dinner started to gather in the kitchen.

Allison went straight to her room and shut the door.

She sat on her bed and stared at her phone for a long moment before unlocking it.

Then she opened Notes.

* * *

| i keep thinking about the second i froze.

| not the fall.

| not the laughing.

| the moment where i could've moved.

| i didn't.

| i keep replaying it like i'm trying to rewrite it.

| like if i replay it enough times i'll find the version where i'm better.

| i don't.

| i don't know if anyone noticed me not moving.
| i don't know if that's why it feels so bad.
|
| because maybe nobody noticed.
| and i'm still the one who has to live with it.
|
| kara asked if i saw it.
| like it was just a thing that happened.
|
| she was mad for rachel.
| and then she laughed about something else five
minutes later.
|
| i don't mean that like she's a bad person.
| i mean it like... how does everyone do that?
|
| how do they metabolize it?
|
| i wanted her to stay mad longer.
| and then i hated myself for wanting that.
|
| because rachel is the one who got hurt.
| not me.
|
| and i didn't even help.
|
| i didn't want anything bad to happen.
| i just wanted it to stop.
|
| i thought that.
| just once.
| i wish they'd leave her alone.
|
| and then the video was gone.
|
| i don't know if that means anything.

| i don't know if it would've happened anyway.
|
| but the relief hit me so fast it scared me.
|
| because relief means i wanted it.
| and wanting it feels like reaching.
|
| what if reaching is all it takes?
|
| i don't want to be responsible.
|
| i don't want to be the kind of person who
hesitates
| and then "fixes" something after it's already
done.
|
| i don't know if my silence counts as a choice.
|
| but it felt like one.
|
| and i don't know what to do with that.
|
| i don't know how to stop thinking.
| and i don't know how to stop noticing.
|
| i wish i could go back to when my thoughts
didn't feel like they mattered.
|
| because this feels like being trapped inside my
own head.
* * *

Chapter 4 — Rules for the Day

Allison woke up already braced.

Not for anything specific. Just for the idea of the day itself—its length, its unpredictability, the way it would unfold whether she felt ready or not.

The house sounded the same as always. Emily's door opened and closed. Someone turned on the shower. The kitchen light flicked on downstairs. Normal noises, in a normal order.

Allison lay still for a moment and tried to decide how to exist inside it.

She sat up slowly, careful not to think too hard while she did it. Her body felt stiff, like she'd slept wrong, but she knew it wasn't that. It was the same tightness she'd been carrying since yesterday, lodged somewhere behind her ribs. She reached for her phone and stopped herself. Not the notes. Not yet.

Downstairs, breakfast unfolded without friction. Emily talked about something from social media—someone's outfit, someone else's comment thread. Their parents half-listened, responding when expected, moving through their morning like it was a script they'd rehearsed enough times to stop paying attention to.

Allison ate, nodded when necessary, answered questions with as few words as possible.

"You're quiet again," her mom said, glancing at her.

"I'm just tired," Allison said.

It was becoming her default answer. It worked because it was unprovable.

Her mom studied her for a second longer than usual, then nodded. "Don't forget your lunch."

“I won’t.”

Allison rinsed her bowl, grabbed her bag, and left before the conversation could deepen into something she didn’t have the energy to navigate. Outside, the air was cold and clear, sharp enough to cut through the fog in her head. The street was quiet, early enough that most people were still inside. Allison walked with her hands tucked into her sleeves, shoulders hunched slightly forward. Halfway down the block, she started making rules.

She didn’t mean to. It just... happened.

Don’t wish for anything today.

That one came first, immediate and obvious.

Don’t think about wishing either, she added quickly, like she could outpace her own thoughts if she moved fast enough.

The sidewalk stretched out ahead of her, familiar cracks and uneven patches marking time. Allison stepped over a long split in the concrete without looking down.

Don’t want things, she told herself.

That one felt harder.

She tried again, softer. Just don’t want anything big.

The problem with rules was that they required clarity.

Allison didn’t have any.

She tried to simplify them as she walked, breaking them down into smaller, more manageable pieces.

Don’t want things was too vague. Wanting was constant, automatic. Wanting warmth when the wind cut through her sleeves. Wanting the walk to be shorter. Wanting the day to already be over. She amended it.

Don't want outcomes.

That felt smarter. More precise.

Except outcomes were everywhere too. Outcomes were bells ringing and teachers calling on students and assignments being due whether she felt ready or not.

Her steps slowed without her noticing.

A car passed too close to the curb and splashed water from a shallow puddle onto the sidewalk.

Allison jumped, heart stuttering, then exhaled sharply at herself.

Get it together.

She hated that phrase. Hated how often she used it. Like her emotions were something scattered she was responsible for gathering back into place.

By the time she reached the edge of the school grounds, the rules felt less like guidelines and more like apologies she was rehearsing for a version of herself that didn't exist yet.

By the time the school building came into view, Allison felt like she'd already failed at something she couldn't quite name.

The hallway noise hit her all at once—lockers, voices, laughter bouncing off tile and metal.

Allison moved through it automatically, her body remembering the routes her mind was busy monitoring.

Just get through the day, she told herself.

In first period, she slid into her seat and kept her eyes on her desk. The teacher droned on about attendance, announcements, things Allison barely registered.

Then the classroom door opened.

"Before we start," the teacher said, glancing toward the doorway, "we have a new student joining us today."

Allison looked up despite herself.

The boy standing at the front of the room didn't look nervous. He didn't look overly confident either. He just stood there, hands at his sides, posture relaxed but attentive, like he was waiting for something specific to happen.

"Everyone, this is Evan," the teacher continued.

"He's just transferred in. Evan, you can take the empty seat near the back."

Allison's stomach tightened.

She didn't tell it to do that.

Evan nodded, murmured something that might have been a thank you, and started down the aisle.

Allison looked away quickly, focusing on the edge of her notebook. She could feel him passing without seeing him, like a shift in air pressure.

When he slid into the empty seat two rows over, she resisted the urge to glance back.

Rules, she reminded herself.

Her body didn't care.

She told herself she was only aware of Evan because he was new.

Newness always stood out.

That explanation lasted exactly three seconds.

She felt him before she saw him again, a subtle shift in the room that made her spine straighten.

She focused harder on the teacher's voice, on the board, on the steady scratch of her pen.

Don't notice.

Her body ignored her.

She could sense the direction of his attention without looking. It wasn't heavy or invasive. It didn't crawl.

It just... existed.

Like he was listening to something quiet.

Her jaw tightened. She forced herself to move, to flip a page, to act like nothing had changed. Inside, everything felt slightly misaligned. Between classes, they passed each other in the hallway.

It was nothing—just a moment where paths crossed, shoulders narrowly missing. But Evan’s eyes flicked to her face, sharp and curious, like he was noticing something specific.

Allison looked away first.

Her heart thudded too hard for no reason she could explain.

At lunch, Kara dropped into the seat across from her with a grin. “Okay, so. New guy.”

Allison stared at her food. “What about him?”

Kara laughed. “Don’t pretend you didn’t see him. Evan. He’s cute.”

Allison shrugged, deliberately casual. “I guess.”

Kara raised an eyebrow. “That’s it? ‘I guess’?”

“I didn’t really notice,” Allison lied.

Kara scoffed. “Sure you didn’t.”

Kara talked the way people always did when something new entered their orbit—easily, playfully, without weight. Allison watched her and felt like she was on the wrong side of a glass wall.

She wanted to ask Kara if she ever worried about being seen wrong.

If she ever felt like attention was something that stuck to you and didn’t let go.

She didn’t ask.

The questions felt dangerous. The kind that would make Kara look at her differently.

Allison smiled when Kara laughed. She nodded at the right moments. She played her part carefully, afraid that if she slipped even a little, Kara would

notice the strain underneath.
She didn't want to be intense.
She didn't want to be dramatic.
She didn't want to be the girl people lowered
their voices around.
Across the cafeteria, Evan sat alone, eating
quietly, eyes scanning the room in a way that
didn't feel bored.
It felt deliberate.
Allison forced herself to look away.
Don't want anything, she reminded herself.
The thought that slipped through anyway was
small and dangerous:
I wish he wouldn't look at me like that.
She shut it down instantly, breath catching.
No. Not that.
The rest of the day passed with a strange tension
threaded through it.
After school, Allison didn't wait around.
She took the familiar path toward the creek, her
steps quick, mind buzzing.
The creek was quiet when she arrived, sunlight
filtering through bare branches, water moving
steadily over stone.
Allison sat on the bank and tried to do everything
the same way she always did.
She watched the same bend in the water. She
counted her breaths.
It should have worked.
It didn't.
The quiet felt louder instead of softer. The space
felt different. Less private.
She glanced over her shoulder even though she
knew she was alone.
For the first time, Allison wondered if the creek
had ever actually calmed her—or if it had just

given her permission to be alone with herself.
Eventually, she stood and headed home,
unsettled.

In her room, Allison shut the door and sat on her
bed, phone in hand. She hesitated only a second
before opening Notes.

* * *

| i made rules today.

| i don't know when i started doing that.

| rules about thinking.

| about wanting.

| about noticing.

| they didn't work.

| there's a new guy at school.

| i don't want to write his name here.

| like that would make it worse somehow.

| he looked at me.

| not like everyone else looks.

| just... aware.

| i don't like how much that bothers me.

| i don't like that part of me wants to be unseen
| and another part wants to be understood.

| i don't know which one is more dangerous.

| the creek didn't help today.

| it felt like something had changed.
| even though nothing actually happened.

|
| i keep thinking about attention
| like it's something physical.

|
| like it sticks.

|
| like once someone notices you,
| you don't get to decide what they see.

|
| i don't know if i'm hiding
| or just waiting.

|
| i don't know what the difference is.

|
| i don't think isolation works
| if someone else is paying attention.

|
| i don't know what that means yet.

|
| but it scares me more than yesterday did.

* * *

Chapter 5 — Perimeter

Allison tried not to look for him.

She failed before she even got through the front doors.

It wasn't deliberate—not in the way she would have accused herself of if she'd had the energy. It was the kind of noticing that happened before thought, like your eyes tracking movement without asking permission. Like your body deciding something mattered and refusing to explain why.

She walked the same path through the hallway she always did, slipping between clusters of people, keeping her face neutral. She kept her gaze mostly forward, occasionally dropping it to her locker combination as if numbers could anchor her.

Rules, she reminded herself.

She'd made them yesterday like they meant something.

Don't wish.

Don't want.

Don't notice.

In the cold light of morning, they felt less like rules and more like a superstition.

Allison slowed as she approached her locker, aware of every inch of space around her in a way that felt almost predatory.

She could feel people passing behind her, close enough that the fabric of their sleeves brushed the air near her arms. Voices overlapped in bursts—inside jokes, complaints, half-finished sentences that didn't need to include her.

She wondered if people ever noticed how much effort it took just to stand normally.

She rolled her shoulders back, then immediately worried she'd done it too deliberately. She shifted her weight, then worried that looked uncertain.

There was no neutral way to exist once she started thinking about it.

Stop, she told herself. You're fine.

She focused on the dial.

Thirty-six.

Twenty-one.

Back to nine.

The numbers steadied her hands, even as her chest stayed tight.

She told herself she was being ridiculous. That this was just a hallway. Just a morning. Just another day she'd walked this exact path a hundred times before.

The feeling didn't go away.

She reached her locker and spun the dial with careful precision. The metal was cold under her fingertips. Her hands didn't shake, which felt like a victory even though it shouldn't have mattered.

Voices swelled around her. Laughter. The slam of locker doors. A teacher telling someone to take their hood down. Normal, normal, normal.

Allison's brain tried to relax into it.

Then she felt it—the shift.

Not sound, not movement. Something subtler.

Like a new weight in the air, like the space behind her had changed density.

She didn't turn.

She kept her eyes on her books, sliding one out, swapping it for another, moving with exaggerated calm.

“Hey.”

The word landed close enough that she felt it in her ribs.

Allison's fingers froze on the edge of her binder. She knew that voice already. Calm. Measured. Not loud enough to draw attention, but placed like it was meant to be heard.

She forced herself to breathe in and out before she turned.

Evan stood a few feet away, not crowding her space, not leaning. Just... present. His backpack was slung over one shoulder. His expression was neutral in a way that didn't feel blank. It felt attentive.

Allison's pulse ticked up.

"Hi," she managed.

Evan glanced at her locker, then back to her face.

"Is it always this loud in here?"

Allison blinked. "It's... school."

A flicker of something crossed his expression.

Almost a smile. Not quite.

"Right," he said. "I'm still adjusting."

Allison nodded like that was a normal thing to say. Like this was a normal conversation she was built for.

She wasn't.

"Are you—" Evan paused, eyes shifting briefly past her shoulder as a group of girls walked by, laughing. When he looked back, his gaze landed on her with the same quiet precision as before.

"Are you okay?"

For half a second, Allison almost told the truth. Not the whole truth. Just something small and manageable. Something like I'm tired or I didn't sleep well or school's just been weird lately. The words stacked up behind her teeth, pressing forward.

Then she imagined Evan responding.
Imagined concern, or worse—understanding.
Her chest tightened sharply.
“I’m fine,” she said instead.
The relief she felt was immediate and sour.
Evan didn’t look disappointed.
That somehow made her chest ache.
She watched his face for signs—confusion,
judgment, boredom—and found none of them.
Just attention, steady and unhurried.
Like he wasn’t waiting for her to be different.
Like he was waiting for her to be honest.
The thought scared her enough that she forced her
gaze down, pretending to check the books in her
bag.
Evan didn’t push. He didn’t fill the silence.
He nodded once, like he was filing her answer
away somewhere.
Allison’s hands tightened around her binder. She
forced her grip to loosen.
“Sorry,” she added. “I’m just... tired.”
Evan’s gaze dropped to her hands for half a
second.
Then he looked up again, and his voice stayed
calm. “Yeah. You seem tired.”
Allison felt heat rise in her face.
Seen.
Her mind started throwing rules at her faster than
she could catch them.
Don’t react.
Don’t say something weird.
Don’t think about how he said that.
Don’t wish he’d stop looking at you.
The last one slipped through like a splinter.
Allison swallowed hard.

Evan shifted his weight slightly, glancing down the hallway as if checking time. "Anyway," he said, like he was giving her an exit. "I just... wanted to say hi. I don't know anyone yet."

Allison's chest tightened.

She knew what it felt like not to know anyone. To exist on the edges of rooms, pretending you weren't alone.

But Evan didn't feel like the kind of person who got stuck on the edges.

That thought made her suspicious. Of him. Of herself.

"Yeah," she said, then realized she hadn't actually answered him. "Hi."

Evan's mouth twitched. "Okay."

Then, before she could decide whether to speak again, he nodded once and moved on, slipping into the flow of students like he belonged there.

Allison watched him go.

She hated herself for watching.

She hated that part of her was already replaying it.

When she finally looked away, Kara was standing a few lockers down with her eyebrows raised.

"Oh my god," Kara said, grinning. "He talked to you."

Allison's stomach dropped. "No."

Kara laughed. "Yes. I literally watched it happen."

Allison turned back to her locker, pretending to be busy. "He just said hi."

Kara leaned closer. "He said hi to you."

"I wanted to run away," Allison muttered.

Kara snorted. "Sure you did. You're blushing."

"I'm not."

"You are."

Allison shut her locker harder than she meant to.
The sound echoed. She flinched.

Kara's grin softened. "Okay, okay. I'm teasing.
But seriously—what was that about?"

Allison forced a shrug. "Nothing."

Kara studied her for a beat. "You've been weird
today."

Allison's stomach tightened.

"I'm just tired," she said.

Kara chewed on her straw. "You keep saying
that."

Allison smiled. "It's been a week."

Kara accepted the answer, but something about
her expression shifted—not suspicion. Distance.

The guilt hit harder than Allison expected.

She wasn't lying.

She just wasn't telling the truth either.

Allison spent the rest of the morning struggling to
focus.

In English, she stared at the same paragraph
without absorbing a single word. Her foot

bounced under the desk until she forced it still.

She kept expecting something to happen.

That was the worst part—the waiting.

When the teacher began calling on students to
read aloud, dread rose automatically.

She clamped down on the familiar wish.

No wishing.

The names moved closer.

Then skipped her.

Just like that.

Relief hit first.

Then fear.

She was sure she hadn't wished.

By lunch, Allison felt hollowed out by vigilance.

Kara talked like nothing had changed—teachers, quizzes, someone’s boyfriend drama. Allison smiled when expected, laughed once when appropriate.

Across the cafeteria, Evan sat alone again.

Not lonely.

Unclaimed.

It didn’t make her relax.

After school, Allison didn’t wait around.

She left with her head down and her pace just fast enough that no one could accuse her of lingering.

She crossed the street and turned onto the narrower side road that led away from the school. She didn’t look back.

She knew better than to look back.

The late afternoon light flattened everything into muted blues and grays. Houses blurred past. Her feet fell into the rhythm she usually relied on.

It didn’t work today.

She turned down the side street that led toward the creek path, pavement cracking into dirt, weeds pressing in.

The sound of traffic faded.

She felt it again—that subtle shift.

“Allison?”

Her name stopped her cold.

She turned slowly, heart slamming.

Evan stood several yards back, hands lifted slightly. “Sorry,” he said quickly. “I didn’t mean to scare you.”

“It’s fine,” she said automatically.

“You go this way a lot?” he asked.

“Sometimes.”

“I’m still figuring out how to get home,” he said.

“This town’s smaller than I expected.”

“Yeah,” she said. “That happens.”

“You’re from here, right?”

“Yeah. Born somewhere else. I don’t remember it.”

“Do you like it?”

She hesitated. “It’s just... the kind of place where people already think they know you.”

Evan nodded. “Even if they don’t?”

She looked at him, surprised.

“Where’d you move from?” she asked.

“Michigan,” he said. “My dad got transferred. We’ve moved before, but this one feels different.”

“How?”

“Quieter,” he said. “Like things are happening under the surface and no one talks about them.”

Her fingers curled into her sleeves.

They walked together as the path narrowed.

“You seem like you notice stuff,” Evan said.

“I don’t,” she said too quickly.

He smiled faintly. “You do. You just don’t draw attention to it.”

She stared at the ground. “I try not to.”

“Why?”

“I don’t know,” she said. “It’s easier.”

“I guess I notice people,” Evan said after a moment. “Maybe more than I should.”

She swallowed.

They reached the clearing.

“This is where I usually sit,” she said.

“I get why,” Evan said quietly.

“It’s just a place.”

“Yeah,” he said. “But some places are different.”

She hugged her arms around herself. “I should head home.”

“Yeah. Of course.”

They walked back together.

“Thanks,” Evan said. “For letting me walk with you.”

She nodded. “Yeah.”

“I’m glad I ran into you,” he added.

Her stomach flipped.

“Me too,” she said.

He smiled once. “See you tomorrow?”

“Yeah.”

He turned away.

Allison stayed until he disappeared, then sat down hard at the edge of the path, the creek suddenly too close.

Not hers anymore.

* * *

| i don’t know when being seen started to feel dangerous.

| i think maybe it always was.

| or maybe i just didn’t notice before
| because no one was really looking.

| he talked to me today.

| i don’t want to write his name.

| i keep thinking if i don’t,
| this won’t turn into something else.

| he asked if i was okay.

| people ask that all the time.
| it shouldn’t have mattered.

| but it did.

| it felt like he was waiting.
| not for an answer.

| just... for me.
|
| i told him i was fine.
| i always say that.
|
| i don't even know what i would have said
| if i hadn't.
|
| i keep making rules.
| they feel important when i think of them
| and stupid five minutes later.
|
| i didn't wish today.
| i'm almost sure i didn't.
|
| but something still happened.
|
| maybe i'm wrong about how this works.
| or maybe that's worse.
|
| kara looked at me like she knew
| i wasn't telling her everything.
|
| i don't want to lie to her.
| i just don't know how to explain
| without sounding insane.
|
| i want things to stay normal.
|
| i want to stop thinking.
|
| i want to go back to not noticing
| when people look at me differently.
|
| i don't know if that's possible anymore.

* * *

* * *

Chapter 6

Morning arrived on time.

That, more than anything else, unsettled Allison. The alarm went off when it always did. The light through her window looked the same—pale, uncommitted, the color of a day that hadn't decided what it wanted to be yet. Her room held its familiar shapes: desk, chair, the half-closed closet door. Nothing was out of place.

She lay still longer than usual, listening.

The house made its normal sounds. Pipes shifting. The muted rhythm of movement downstairs. A cupboard opening, then closing. Someone's footsteps crossing the kitchen. The old refrigerator made its familiar click-hum-click, like it was thinking about working and then remembering it already was.

Everything continued.

When Allison finally sat up, she moved carefully, as if speed itself might draw attention. She swung her legs off the bed and paused, waiting for the strange pressure she'd half-expected to return—the feeling from the day before that she hadn't quite been able to describe.

Nothing happened.

That didn't help.

In the bathroom mirror, she studied her own reflection longer than necessary. She didn't look different. No shadows clung to her. No marks lingered on her skin. Her eyes were the same shade they'd always been—brown, ordinary, easy to ignore. She brushed her teeth, rinsed, wiped the fog from the glass with her sleeve, and checked again.

Still normal.

Her hands were steady, which felt wrong all by itself. She'd expected shaking. She'd expected her body to betray her, to prove something had changed. Instead, her body behaved like it had accepted an explanation she hadn't been given. In her room, she dressed with exaggerated care. She chose jeans and a soft sweater, the kind she could pull her sleeves over her hands if she wanted. She stood in front of her closet for an extra beat, scanning through hangers like there might be one outfit that would keep her safe. The thought was ridiculous, and the ridiculousness didn't make it go away.

She tied her shoes more tightly than usual. She retied the left one twice, because the lace felt uneven, because her fingers needed something to do that wasn't thinking.

Downstairs, the kitchen smelled like toast and something buttery. The radio murmured low from the counter. Her mom stood at the stove in pajama pants and a worn hoodie, flipping eggs in a pan with a competence that made the act look effortless.

"You want some?" her mom asked without looking up.

Allison opened her mouth to say yes, because that was what she usually did. Because eggs meant normal. Routine. A small anchor.

But her stomach tightened, and the idea of chewing felt impossible.

"No," she said too quickly, and the word snapped in the air. She softened it immediately. "I mean—no thanks. I'm not that hungry."

Her mom's hand paused. Not fully—just the smallest hitch, like a skipped beat in a song.

“You feeling okay?” her mom asked, finally glancing over.

Allison managed a shrug that looked casual. She tried to make her face do the right thing. “Yeah. Just... tired.”

Her mom’s eyes stayed on her a second longer than usual. Not suspicious. Concerned. The kind of look that made Allison want to confess and also made her want to run.

“You were up late?” her mom asked.

Allison almost said no, then caught herself. If she said no, her mom would ask why she looked tired. If she said yes, her mom would ask what kept her up. Either answer led to more questions.

“A little,” Allison said. “Homework.”

Her mom nodded, accepting it because it sounded plausible, because it was the kind of lie that was mostly true. “Eat a banana at least,” she said.

“You’ll crash by third period.”

Across the table, her mom scanned her phone with the same focused frown she used for bills.

“Your aunt texted,” she said, half to herself. “She wants to do dinner Sunday.”

“Okay,” Allison said.

Her mom looked up again. “You sure you’re okay?”

“I’m fine,” Allison said, a little sharper than she meant.

Her mom’s face softened, not offended. “Hey,” she said gently. “If something’s going on, you can tell me.”

Allison’s throat tightened. The words that rose up were messy, impossible. *I think something saw me. I think I did something. I don’t know how.* Instead she said, “It’s nothing.”

Her mom studied her, then nodded like she was choosing not to push. “Okay,” she said, and let the conversation end there. But she watched Allison’s hands while she rinsed her plate. She watched the way Allison checked the lock twice before leaving.

Outside, the cold bit at Allison’s cheeks. The air smelled like damp leaves and distant exhaust. She walked faster than she needed to, as if motion could keep the wrongness from catching up.

The route to school was the same. The cracked sidewalk by the Johnsons’ yard. The corner where the big oak dropped acorns like little warnings. The empty lot where someone had tried to build something once and quit halfway.

Allison knew each landmark the way you knew your own street in the dark. She’d walked it a hundred times without thinking. Today, she noticed everything. She counted steps between driveways. She watched shadows for movement. She listened for a sound that didn’t belong.

Nothing did.

A car rolled slowly past, headlights on even though the sun was up. Allison’s pulse spiked anyway. The car kept going.

At school, the hallways were already loud.

Lockers slammed. Someone laughed too hard at something that wasn’t funny. The bell hadn’t rung yet, but everyone moved with the same unconscious urgency, the shared understanding of where they were supposed to be and when.

Allison stepped into the flow and let it carry her. The noise hit her like a wall. Voices layered over voices. Sneakers squeaking on linoleum. The metallic clack of locker doors. The high, sharp sound of a girl’s laugh that made Allison’s teeth

ache.

She became acutely aware of her own movements—how close she stood to others, how long she held eye contact, the way her hands curled around the straps of her bag. She adjusted herself constantly, tiny corrections she couldn't stop making. Nothing about her felt wrong. But nothing felt effortless either.

Someone bumped her shoulder. "Sorry," a boy mumbled without looking back.

"It's fine," Allison said automatically, though her heart was already racing.

She reached her locker and fumbled the combination once before forcing herself to slow down.

"Al," Emily's voice said behind her.

Allison's shoulders tightened before she turned. Emily leaned against the lockers like she always did, one hip popped, hair pulled into a messy ponytail that somehow still looked intentional. She held a coffee cup that definitely didn't come from the cafeteria. Emily's eyes were bright, assessing.

"You were weird yesterday," Emily said, not unkindly, not accusing. Just observant.

Allison's stomach clenched. She forced a laugh that sounded thin even to her. "Was I?"

"Yeah," Emily said. "Just... quiet. You left early."

"Oh." Allison shut her locker too hard and winced at the sound. "I had a headache."

Emily's eyebrows lifted. "Since when do you get headaches?"

Allison opened her mouth and nothing came out fast enough. The question wasn't hostile. That made it worse. Emily knew her well enough to

notice patterns. Emily was the kind of person who connected dots for fun.

"I don't know," Allison said. "Maybe I was dehydrated."

Emily studied her for half a second longer than necessary, then took a sip of coffee like she was letting Allison off the hook. "Okay," she said.

"Well. If you ditch me again, at least text."

"I didn't ditch you," Allison said, too defensive. Emily's mouth tilted. "Uh-huh."

A group of freshmen shoved past, loud and oblivious. One of them glanced at Allison, then away, the way people did when they weren't actually seeing you.

Emily watched Allison's face. "Seriously, are you okay?"

Allison wanted to say yes. She wanted to say no. She wanted to say, *I'm not sure if okay is even a real thing anymore.*

"I'm fine," she said.

Emily didn't argue, but her eyes didn't leave.

"You look like you didn't sleep," she said.

Allison swallowed. "I slept."

"Then why do you look like you didn't?"

Allison's laugh came out again, too sharp.

"Thanks."

Emily rolled her eyes. "You know what I mean."

The first bell rang, and the hallway surged. Emily pushed off the lockers. "Text me at lunch," she said. "Or I'll come find you."

Allison nodded. "Okay."

Emily walked away, and Allison stood there for an extra beat, watching her disappear into the crowd. The moment Emily was gone, Allison felt exposed, like the only person left standing still in a room full of motion.

In first period, Allison stared at the board without absorbing anything. The fluorescent lights buzzed overhead, steady and flat.

She copied notes because her hand knew how, even when her mind wandered. Once, she realized she'd been holding her breath and had to consciously let it out.

The teacher paused near her desk.

"Allison?"

She looked up too fast. "Sorry."

"It's fine," the teacher said, already moving on.

"Just checking."

A girl in the row behind Allison whispered something and giggled. Allison's face went hot. She couldn't tell if it was about her. That uncertainty gnawed.

At lunch, she sat at the edge of her usual table and tried to eat fries. The salt tasted too sharp. Emily slid into the seat beside her.

"You didn't text," Emily said.

Allison blinked. "I—sorry. I forgot."

Emily frowned. "You never forget."

Allison's hands tightened around her milk carton.

"I've just got... stuff."

Emily leaned in slightly, lowering her voice.

"What kind of stuff?"

Allison stared at the cafeteria and shook her head.

"I don't know. I just feel off."

Emily's expression softened. "Okay," she said.

"Then don't do it alone."

Emily didn't push further. She took a fry, ate it, and said, "If you want to skip practice today, I'll cover."

Allison shook her head. "No. I'll go."

Emily made a face, but let it drop. "Fine," she said. "But if you freak out again, I'm not carrying

you. You're heavy."

Allison snorted, surprised by the sound. For a moment, the tension loosened. Then it returned, like a hand settling back on her shoulder.

After school, instead of turning straight toward home, Allison kept walking.

It wasn't a decision so much as a delay. The street she followed ran alongside a strip of trees and brush that separated the neighborhood from a shallow creek. She'd walked this way plenty of times before, sometimes alone, sometimes with friends. There was nothing special about it.

That was the point.

She reached the narrow dirt path leading down toward the water and stopped. No signs. No fences. Just an opening where people had passed often enough to make the ground remember.

The trees muffled the neighborhood noise. The air smelled like wet earth and cold water. Allison stood there, backpack heavy, and listened.

She half-expected something to happen.

A sound. A feeling. Anything.

Nothing did.

The quiet stretched. Not peaceful—just empty.

The kind of empty that made you aware of your own heartbeat.

Allison stepped onto the path and followed it down. Leaves stuck to her shoes. The ground was soft from recent rain. She stopped where the creek came into view, shallow and clear enough to see stones beneath the surface. Sunlight flickered across it in fragments, bright in a way that felt careless.

She crouched, resting her arms on her knees.

Her chest felt tight in a way that had nothing to do with breathing.

“This is stupid,” she murmured, though she wasn’t sure what she meant.

The words didn’t echo. The creek didn’t respond. The world didn’t care that she was there.

Allison stared at the water until her legs started to ache. Ordinary rules. Ordinary movement.

Nothing she could grab.

Allison stood, brushing dirt from her hands. She turned back toward the path, then paused again, suddenly certain someone was behind her.

She looked.

No one.

The certainty didn’t fade. It settled deeper, like a splinter.

By the time she reached home, the day felt both long and unfinished. Her house greeted her the way it always did. Shoes by the door. A jacket slung over a chair. The quiet hum of something running in the background.

Her mom was on the couch with a blanket over her legs, flipping through channels like she couldn’t pick a reality to settle into. She looked up when Allison came in.

“You’re late,” her mom said, not angry. Just noting it.

“I walked,” Allison said.

Her mom’s eyes narrowed a little. “Why?”

Allison shrugged, dropping her backpack by the door. “Needed air.”

Her mom patted the couch beside her. “Come sit for a minute.”

Allison hesitated. Sitting meant being seen. It meant questions.

She sat anyway, perching on the edge of the cushion.

Her mom muted the TV. The sudden quiet made Allison's skin prickle.

"You sure you're okay?" her mom asked again. Allison's hands twisted in her lap. "I'm fine." Her mom watched her for a long moment, then softened. "If you're stressed, we can talk about it," she said.

Her mom reached out and tucked a strand of hair behind Allison's ear, a gesture so normal it made Allison's eyes sting. "If someone at school—" "No," Allison said quickly. "It's not that."

Her mom watched her. "Then what is it?" Allison's chest tightened. She could feel the truth pressing at the back of her teeth, trying to become sound. If she said it out loud, would it become real? Would it spill into the room like smoke? "I just..." Allison swallowed. "I feel like... everything is normal and I'm not."

Her mom's expression softened. "Honey," she said, "that happens. Sometimes you're just... overwhelmed."

Allison nodded, because that was an explanation her mom could hold. It was neat. It fit inside the world they lived in.

But it wasn't the whole thing.

Her mom squeezed her hand once, then let go. "Go do your homework," she said, trying for lightness. "And eat something later. Real food." "All right," Allison said.

Upstairs, her room felt too quiet. She dropped onto her bed and stared at the ceiling.

She tried to replay yesterday in her head, but each time she reached the part that mattered, her mind slid away. Like touching the edge of a dream after waking. She knew something had been there. She just couldn't hold it long enough to examine it.

Her phone buzzed. Emily: **u alive**

Allison typed: **yeah. just tired.**

Emily: **ok. dont be weird tomorrow.**

Allison laughed once, more breath than sound.

She set the phone down and listened to the house.

Her mom moving in the kitchen. The distant television. Pipes. The refrigerator.

Everything was still working.

That didn't mean everything was okay.

* * *

Chapter 7 — The Cost of Staying Close

The bell rang like nothing had happened. That was the part Allison hated most—the way sound itself refused to acknowledge consequence. The same sharp tone cut through the hallway, the same flood of bodies moved in the same practiced rhythm. If you closed your eyes, you could pretend yesterday was a bad dream and not a real day that had happened to her.

Allison kept her eyes open anyway. She moved with the crowd, but she didn't let it carry her the way it usually did. Her shoulders stayed slightly lifted, like she was bracing for a shove that might come. She held her backpack straps tight enough to make her knuckles pale. Emily had texted her last night—**dont be weird tomorrow**—and Allison had laughed, a real laugh, for about half a second. Then she'd set her phone down and stared at the ceiling until the house noises softened and her thoughts got quieter.

This morning, she didn't feel weird. She felt watched.

Not in the way you felt when someone stared. Not in the way your mom looked at you when she asked if you were okay. More like a sense that the day had weight, and she was moving under it. In first period, her teacher's voice washed over the class, steady and practical. Allison wrote down what she was supposed to write down. Dates. Definitions. A list of things that were true because they were printed in a book. She didn't look at the clock until she had to.

When the bell rang again, the classroom exhaled. Chairs scraped back. People stood. Allison waited for the surge to happen so she could step into it at the right moment—close enough to be normal, far enough to keep her space.

“Hey.”

Kara’s voice was quiet, like she didn’t trust the hallway to hear her.

Allison turned and saw her standing near the door, hood up despite the school’s no-hoods rule, the fabric shadowing her face. Kara’s hair stuck out at the edges in uneven pieces. Her backpack hung off one shoulder, like she’d forgotten how to wear it properly.

No one stopped her.

That, too, felt new.

Yesterday, a hood like that would have drawn whispers. A reminder. A joke. Someone enforcing a rule just to see her flinch. Today, people slid past Kara like she was a post they weren’t supposed to touch.

Allison’s stomach tightened. “You okay?”

Kara’s mouth twitched. Not quite a smile. “Sure.”

It was the kind of sure that meant no.

Allison glanced down the hall. Emily was somewhere in the crowd, laughing at something someone said. Rachel was also somewhere—Rachel was always somewhere, like she belonged to the building itself.

Allison took a step closer to Kara. “Want to walk?”

Kara hesitated, then nodded once.

They fell into the stream together.

It should have been comforting, staying close.

Kara was one of the few people who didn’t ask Allison to perform. Kara didn’t insist on

cheerfulness or jokes or pretending everything was fine.

But closeness had started to feel like a responsibility.

Like if Allison stood too close, she might be counted as part of whatever happened to Kara. Or worse—like she might be the reason it happened at all.

Kara kept her head down as they moved. A few people glanced their way and looked away too fast. The hallway was full of tiny, flickering moments like that—attention sparked and then snuffed out.

“What’s wrong?” Allison asked under her breath.

Kara didn’t answer right away. She just kept walking until they reached the intersection near the stairwell, where the crowd broke into smaller groups.

Then she said, “They posted it.”

Allison’s pulse jumped. “Posted what?”

Kara’s shoulders rose and fell in a stiff shrug. “A video. From yesterday. My... thing.”

Allison’s mouth went dry. Yesterday hadn’t been simple. It hadn’t been loud. It had been the kind of wrong that happened quietly inside Kara, the kind of distress that didn’t make sense to anyone watching from the outside.

Allison had intervened—indirectly, instinctively—without anyone seeing her do it. Without anyone understanding what she’d done. And now there was a video.

Allison forced her voice steady. “Who posted it?”

Kara’s laugh came out short and bitter. “Does it matter?”

Yes, Allison thought. It mattered like a name mattered. Like a target mattered.

But she didn't say that.

Kara pulled her phone from her pocket and held it out like it weighed too much. "I didn't watch it," she said. "Rachel sent it to me. Like a gift."

Allison's skin prickled. "Let me see."

Kara didn't move for a beat, then unlocked her phone and scrolled with her thumb. Her hands were shaking. Kara tried to hide it by holding the phone closer to her body, but Allison saw anyway.

There it was: a shaky clip, grainy and too close, filmed from across the cafeteria. Kara on the floor near the vending machines, half curled in on herself, face pinched with something that looked like fear and pain and embarrassment all at once. The caption under the post was worse than the video.

Allison's vision narrowed.

She felt something rise in her chest like heat, fast and sharp. Her fingers tingled. The hallway noise dimmed for a fraction of a second, like someone had turned down the volume.

She knew that feeling now. Not the shape of it, not the rules. But the edge of it—how it started, how it pulled at her attention and asked for permission.

Allison's breath hitched.

Kara's eyes flicked up, startled. "Allison?"

Allison forced air into her lungs. In. Out. Her nails dug into her palm through the fabric of her sleeve. She kept her face blank even as her body wanted to do something—anything—to make this stop.

She handed the phone back carefully, like it was fragile. "Don't watch it," she said, voice low.

Kara swallowed. "Too late."

Allison's stomach turned. "You did?"

"I saw... the first second," Kara whispered. "And the comments. Then I closed it." Her voice cracked on the last word. "There are so many." Allison wanted to rip the phone out of Kara's hand and throw it down the stairwell. She wanted to walk straight to Rachel and say something that would burn.

Instead she said, "Let's go to the bathroom."

Kara blinked. "Why?"

"Because," Allison said, and softened. "Because you shouldn't be standing in the hallway with that on your screen."

Kara nodded once, small.

They moved toward the nearest bathroom like they were walking through water. Allison kept her shoulders squared. She kept her face neutral. The urge in her chest pressed harder each time she saw someone smirking at their own phone. In the bathroom, the air smelled like cheap soap and floral disinfectant. The fluorescent lights were too bright. The mirror over the sink reflected them both in clean, merciless detail—two girls trying to pretend they were fine. Kara leaned against the counter and stared at the tile floor.

Allison turned on the faucet, more for noise than for need. Water rushed, loud and steady. She watched it hit the basin and splash back in tiny, frantic droplets.

"Who else knows?" Allison asked.

Kara's voice was thin. "Everyone. It's on Snap. Someone put it on TikTok too." She finally looked up, eyes shiny. "It's not even just the video. They made... edits. Like music. Like it's funny."

Allison's throat tightened. "It's not funny."

"I know," Kara whispered, as if she needed to hear Allison say it out loud.

Allison shut off the water. The silence that followed felt like a trap.

She pulled her phone from her pocket and opened her notes, the same one she'd started using like a place to put things she couldn't say. Her thumb hovered over the screen.

Kara watched her. "What are you doing?"

Allison didn't answer, because she didn't know how to answer. *I'm trying not to break something.* *I'm trying to keep you safe.* *I'm trying to figure out what part of this is me.*

Instead she said, "I'm going to report it."

Kara's expression tightened. "They'll just post it again."

"Maybe," Allison said. "But I'm still doing it."

She navigated to the school's anonymous reporting form, the one no one trusted because no one believed anything happened from it. She filled in the details, attaching the link Kara showed her. Her hands were steadier than Kara's, but her heart felt like it was hitting the inside of her ribs.

Kara let out a humorless laugh. "You really think they care?"

Allison didn't look up. "I think it matters that someone does something."

Kara's eyes narrowed. "You're acting like it's your job."

The words hit harder than Allison expected.

Allison's fingers froze over her screen. "It's not my job," she said quietly.

"Then why," Kara said, and her voice wobbled, "does it feel like it is?"

Allison swallowed. She stared at the half-filled form. She could feel the pressure in her chest again, the urge. It wasn't rage exactly. It was... focus. A tightening, like the world wanted to become simpler if she would just decide.

Allison didn't decide. Not fully.

She hit submit on the report form. A small, cheerful confirmation message popped up:

Thank you for your report.

The words felt insulting.

Kara wiped her face with her sleeve and turned away, pretending she was adjusting her hood. "I have to go," she said. "I can't do this all day."

Allison nodded, because arguing would make it worse. "Do you want me to come with you?"

Kara hesitated. "No."

Allison's stomach sank.

Kara added, softer, "Not because of you. I just... I need to be alone."

Allison nodded again. "Okay."

Kara left the bathroom fast, head down, disappearing into the hallway like she could shrink into the cracks between people.

Allison stared at the closed door.

The urge in her chest surged again, hot and immediate. Her vision sharpened in a way that made the fluorescent lights feel too bright. She could feel the air in the room like it had texture. Her phone buzzed.

Emily: **where r u**

Allison typed back with stiff fingers:

bathroom. kara.

Emily: **oh. rachel being a psycho again?**

Allison stared at the word *psycho* until it blurred. She typed: **yes. dont start anything.**

Emily: **im already starting it**

Allison's pulse spiked.

She shoved her phone in her pocket and left the bathroom.

The hallway was louder now. The video had spread. You could tell by the way people held their phones at an angle, by the little bursts of laughter that didn't connect to any conversation. Allison moved through it like she was walking through smoke.

She found Emily near the cafeteria doors, standing too close to Rachel.

Rachel's hair was glossy and perfect in a way that looked like effort. Her smile was bright. Her eyes were cold.

Emily's voice was low, dangerous. "Take it down."

Rachel lifted her eyebrows. "Take what down?"

Emily's hands were clenched. "You know what."

Rachel's smile widened. "Oh," she said, sweetly.

"You mean Kara's performance? Sorry. I thought we all liked free entertainment."

Allison felt the heat in her chest flare.

For a split second, the sounds around her dipped.

The cafeteria doors seemed to pulse with light, like a photograph overexposed. The air tasted metallic.

Allison stopped walking.

Emily's words blurred as the pressure in Allison's body built, asking for release.

Then she saw someone watching from down the hall.

Evan.

He stood half behind a pillar near the trophy case, like he'd been passing by and stopped. His posture was casual, but his eyes were fixed—on Rachel, on Emily, on Allison.

His gaze flicked to Allison's face at the exact moment Allison's breath caught. And Evan's expression changed. Not into fear. Not into disbelief. Into recognition, like he'd just seen something that didn't fit and couldn't be unseen. Allison's stomach dropped. The pressure inside her sharpened, and she understood, without words, that if she let it out here, in front of Emily and Rachel and Evan and everyone, it would become a story she couldn't control. Allison forced her shoulders down. Forced her jaw to unclench. She dug her nails into her palm again until pain grounded her. The fluorescent lights steadied. The hallway noise returned in full. Rachel's laugh cut through. "Wow, Emily," she said. "Defending Kara now? That's adorable." Emily took a step forward. Allison stepped between them. Emily blinked at her, startled. "Allison—" "Not here," Allison said, quiet but firm. Rachel's eyes slid to Allison. "Oh," she said. "You." The way she said it made Allison's skin crawl, like Rachel had been waiting for her specifically. Rachel tilted her phone. "You want it gone? Make me." Allison's hands went cold. The pressure in her chest rose again, like a wave. Allison did not let it break. She looked at Rachel and said, evenly, "You're not funny." Rachel's smile faltered. Just a flicker.

Allison continued, voice steady because she needed it to be. "You're just loud."

Emily made a sound like she'd been punched in the lungs. Rachel's face shifted, her cheeks flushing.

Then Rachel recovered with a sharp, practiced laugh. "Okay," she said. "Sure." Her eyes narrowed. "Enjoy being boring."

She turned and walked into the cafeteria, hips swaying like she was on a stage.

Emily stared after her, breathing hard. "I hate her," she muttered.

Allison's legs felt weak. "Don't," she said.

Emily turned to Allison, eyes wide. "Don't what? Don't hate her?"

"Don't do this," Allison said, and she hated that her voice sounded like begging. "Not right now."

Emily's expression shifted. "Allison," she said slowly, "what is going on with you?"

Allison shook her head, too fast. "Nothing."

Emily's mouth tightened. "That's a lie."

Allison swallowed. "I can't—"

Evan walked up.

He didn't get close. He stopped a few feet away, like he understood space mattered. His expression was careful. Neutral. But his eyes flicked to Allison's hands, to the way she kept one curled into a fist.

"Hey," Evan said to Emily first, polite, like he wasn't stepping into something volatile. "Coach wants you."

Emily blinked, thrown. "What?"

Evan nodded toward the gym hallway. "He's looking for you. About practice."

Emily looked between Evan and Allison.

Suspicion and concern warred on her face. "Since

when are you Coach's messenger?"

Evan's mouth twitched. "Since I happened to walk by."

Emily huffed, but she was already turning.

"Fine," she said. She pointed at Allison. "Text me." Then she pointed at Evan, like he was part of it now. "And you—don't be weird."

Evan lifted a hand in surrender. "Wouldn't dream of it."

Emily walked away, still fuming.

Allison stood there, suddenly alone with Evan in the hallway.

Her heart pounded.

Evan didn't speak right away. He looked past her shoulder at the cafeteria doors, then back at her face. "Is Kara okay?" he asked.

Allison's throat tightened. "No."

Evan nodded like he'd expected that answer.

"Rachel's... a lot," he said, in the careful tone of someone choosing words that wouldn't make things worse.

Allison stared at him. "Why do you care?"

The question came out sharper than she meant.

She wanted to take it back, but she didn't.

Evan didn't flinch. "Because," he said, and paused. "Because I saw it."

Allison's skin went cold. "Saw what?"

Evan's eyes held hers for a second too long. Then he looked away, like he was giving her the option to pretend he hadn't noticed.

"Nothing," he said quietly.

The word sat between them like a lie they both agreed to.

Allison's breath trembled. The hallway felt too bright, too exposed.

Evan shifted his weight. “If you need... help,” he said, and the word help sounded wrong in his mouth, like he didn’t know what kind of help he meant either. “Just... you know. Don’t do it alone.”

Allison’s chest tightened, not with panic this time but with something like anger. “You don’t even know me.”

Evan’s gaze flicked back to her. “I know enough to know you’re holding yourself together like it’s your job.”

Allison’s throat closed.

Evan’s expression softened, just a fraction.

“Sorry,” he said. “That was... too much.”

Allison forced herself to breathe. “It’s fine,” she lied.

Evan nodded once. “Okay.”

He stepped back, giving her space. “I’m going,” he said. “But... just—be careful.”

Allison watched him walk away, disappearing into the stream of students.

Her hands shook then, finally, when no one was looking closely. She shoved them in her pockets. Not choosing is still choosing, her mind offered, uninvited.

If she stayed close to Kara, she could become a target too. If she stayed close to Emily, she could become the reason Emily exploded. If she did nothing, the video stayed up and Kara carried the humiliation alone.

There wasn’t a safe option.

There was only what she could live with.

After school, she found Kara by the back exit, hood still up, face pale.

Kara didn’t look at her. “You shouldn’t be with me,” she said, voice flat.

Allison's stomach sank. "Don't say that."
Kara's laugh was small and broken. "It's true."
Allison stepped closer anyway. "Walk with me," she said.
Kara hesitated, then nodded once.
They left together, moving along the sidewalk as the school shrank behind them. The air was cold. The sky was the color of wet concrete. Cars passed, splashing through shallow puddles.
Kara didn't speak for a long time.
Allison didn't push.
Finally Kara said, "Did you see it?"
Allison's chest tightened. "Yes."
Kara nodded like she'd expected that too. "And?"
Allison swallowed. "And it was cruel."
Kara's shoulders hunched. "That's not an answer."
Allison glanced at her. Kara's hands were clenched inside her sleeves.
Allison chose her words carefully. "It doesn't get to be who you are," she said.
Kara's mouth twisted. "It already is."
Allison shook her head. "No."
Kara's eyes flicked to Allison's face. "Why are you so sure?"
Allison didn't have a good answer. She didn't have a safe answer.
Because if Allison let the world define Kara by that video, then the world could define Allison too—by her worst moment, by whatever was happening inside her that she couldn't name.
Allison swallowed. "Because I know you," she said simply.
Kara's throat moved. She looked away fast, like she didn't want Allison to see her eyes.

They walked in silence until the street split—Kara's turn toward her neighborhood, Allison's toward hers.

Kara stopped at the corner. "You're going to get dragged into it," she said, voice quiet.

Allison's pulse steadied in a strange, resigned way. "I already am," she said.

Kara nodded once. "Yeah," she whispered. "Me too."

Then Kara turned and walked away, hood up, shoulders tight.

Allison watched until she disappeared.

Only then did Allison let herself breathe like she'd been holding it all day.

She pulled her phone out and opened her notes. She typed one line, then stared at it for a long time.

****Staying close costs something.****

* * *

Chapter 8 — The Space Between What Was Said

The first thing Allison noticed was how quiet the house felt.

Not empty—just careful.

It was the kind of quiet that happened when everyone was home but no one wanted to be the first to make noise. The television murmured faintly from the living room, some daytime show her mom liked to half-watch while folding laundry. The sound felt distant, like it was coming from another house entirely.

Allison shut the front door softly behind her, easing it closed instead of letting it click.

She stood there for a moment, backpack still slung over one shoulder, and listened.

Nothing happened.

That was becoming a pattern.

“Hey,” her mom called. “You’re back early.”

“Yeah,” Allison said. Her voice sounded normal. She hated that she noticed.

She kicked off her shoes and set her backpack down by the stairs. Her hands were trembling just slightly, like her body hadn’t realized the day was over yet.

Her mom appeared in the doorway, a basket of unfolded laundry balanced on her hip. She looked tired in the quiet way—loose hair, faint crease between her eyebrows. The sight of it made Allison’s chest tighten.

“Everything okay?” her mom asked.

Allison hesitated.

The answer was no. The answer was *nothing is okay but I can’t explain why*. The answer was a

mess of images—Kara’s face, Rachel’s smile, the way Evan had looked at her like he was trying to decide whether to speak.

Instead, Allison said, “Can I go upstairs?”

Her mom’s eyebrows lifted. “Sure,” she said, slowly. “But... talk to me later?”

Allison nodded, because nodding was easier than promising. “Okay.”

Upstairs, her room felt smaller than it had that morning. The walls pressed in, not physically, but in the way that made her aware of how much of herself was contained inside them. Posters. Books. A desk cluttered with half-finished homework.

She dropped onto her bed and stared at the ceiling.

The day replayed itself whether she wanted it to or not.

Rachel’s voice. Kara’s hands shaking. The pressure inside her chest that had begged her to *do something*, and the way she’d forced it down until it hurt.

Allison rolled onto her side and pulled her knees up, hugging them close.

She’d stopped it. Mostly.

The hallway hadn’t fractured. The lights hadn’t burst. No one had screamed her name.

But she could still feel where it *would have happened*. The place inside her where everything had narrowed, simplified, waited.

She pressed her palm flat against her chest like she could hold it there.

Her phone buzzed against the bed.

Emily: **u alive again**

Allison closed her eyes for a second before replying.

yeah. home.

Emily: **kara ok?**

Allison swallowed.

not really.

Emily: **rachel is losing her mind rn. admin pulled the video. she's screaming abt censorship**

Allison's pulse spiked.

they took it down?

Emily: **for now. she'll repost. u know her.**

Allison stared at the screen.

For now.

That phrase felt heavier than it should have. Like a shelf everything rested on.

Emily: **you were scary today btw**

Allison frowned.

what do u mean

Emily: **like. calm scary. like u decided something and i couldnt tell what.**

Allison's fingers hovered.

She typed, erased, typed again.

i didnt decide anything.

Emily: **sure u did. u stopped me.**

Allison's stomach clenched. She set the phone face down on the bed.

She wasn't ready to talk about that. She wasn't ready to admit that stopping Emily had taken effort—real effort—that it had felt like holding a door closed against a storm.

A soft knock came at her door.

"Allison?" her mom called.

"Yeah?"

"Can I come in?"

Allison sat up, heart thudding. "Okay."

Her mom opened the door and leaned against the frame instead of coming all the way in, like she

was trying to give Allison space without leaving her alone.

“You hungry?” her mom asked.

Allison shook her head. “Not really.”

Her mom sighed, not frustrated. Worried.

“You’ve barely eaten today.”

“I know.”

Her mom studied her face, eyes sharp in the way only parents’ eyes could be. “Did something happen at school?”

Allison hesitated again.

This time, the words pressed harder. They wanted to come out. They crowded her throat, all tangled together.

“Yes,” Allison said.

Her mom’s posture changed immediately. “What happened?”

Allison picked at a loose thread on her sleeve.

“Someone posted a video. Of Kara.”

Her mom’s mouth tightened. “What kind of video?”

“A bad one.”

“That’s not okay,” her mom said immediately.

“Did you tell anyone?”

“Yes,” Allison said. “The school took it down.”

Her mom nodded, relief flickering across her face. “Good. I’m glad you told someone.”

Allison almost laughed. She hadn’t told the part that mattered.

Her mom watched her closely. “Is that all?”

Allison’s chest felt tight again. “No.”

Her mom waited.

“I almost... did something,” Allison said carefully.

Her mom frowned. “Did something how?”

Allison searched for words that wouldn't sound like lies and wouldn't sound like insanity. "I almost made it worse. I think."

Her mom stepped into the room then, setting the laundry basket down on the floor. She sat on the edge of the bed, close but not touching.

"Allison," she said gently, "wanting to protect your friend doesn't make you dangerous."

Allison shook her head. "You don't understand."

Her mom's voice softened further. "Then help me."

Allison's hands twisted together. "It felt like... like there was a line. And if I crossed it, I wouldn't be able to uncross it."

Her mom was quiet for a long moment.

"That sounds like impulse control," she said slowly. "Or adrenaline. Or anger."

Allison nodded, because those were explanations her mom could hold.

Her mom reached out and rested a hand over Allison's clenched fingers. "I'm proud of you for stopping," she said. "Whatever it was."

Allison's throat tightened. She didn't trust herself to speak.

Her mom squeezed her hand once, then stood.

"Come down and eat some soup later, okay?"

"Okay," Allison whispered.

After her mom left, Allison lay back again, staring at the ceiling.

She felt no pride. No relief.

Only distance.

The space between what she'd wanted to do and what she'd allowed herself to do felt wide and raw, like an open stretch of ground she didn't know how to cross.

Her phone buzzed again.

A number she didn't recognize.

****Evan:**** hey. are you okay?

Allison's breath caught.

She sat up slowly.

****Allison:**** how did you get my number

The typing bubble appeared, disappeared,
appeared again.

****Evan:**** emily. sorry. i wouldnt have if it
wasnt important.

Allison stared at the message.

****Allison:**** important how

There was a longer pause this time.

****Evan:**** i saw something today. and i think you
did too.

Allison's skin prickled.

****Allison:**** saw what

****Evan:**** the moment before you stepped in. the
hallway went quiet. like everything took a breath.

Allison's heart pounded.

****Evan:**** that doesnt just happen.

She could feel it again—the pressure, faint but
present, like a memory in her muscles.

****Allison:**** you're wrong.

The reply came almost immediately.

****Evan:**** maybe. but i dont think so.

She stared at the screen, pulse racing.

****Allison:**** you shouldnt say stuff like that.

****Evan:**** i know. thats why i waited.

Allison swallowed.

****Evan:**** im not trying to freak you out. i
just—if something is happening, pretending it
isnt doesnt make it go away.

The words felt too close. Too accurate.

****Allison:**** im fine.

The lie felt thin.

There was a pause long enough that Allison wondered if he'd stopped typing.

****Evan:**** okay. but if you want someone to notice without turning it into a thing, im here. Allison closed her eyes.

He wasn't offering answers. He wasn't asking her to explain. He was just... acknowledging the space.

****Allison:**** why do you care

Another pause.

****Evan:**** because ive spent most of my life pretending i didnt see things that made me uncomfortable. turns out that doesnt work. Her chest tightened at that.

****Allison:**** that doesnt mean this is your problem

****Evan:**** maybe not. but its yours. and that feels like it should matter.

Allison set the phone down carefully, like it might shatter.

She didn't reply.

Downstairs, a spoon clinked against a bowl. The house shifted around her, settling into evening.

Later, she forced herself to eat soup at the kitchen table. Her mom talked about work. About nothing. Allison nodded at the right places. The lie of normalcy slid back into place.

Back in her room, Allison sat on the floor with her back against the bed.

She thought about Evan's words. *The space.* The quiet moment.

If he'd seen it, that meant it hadn't been entirely inside her. That meant it could be noticed.

Remembered.

She hugged her knees to her chest.

She hadn't crossed the line.

But she knew exactly where it was now.
And that knowledge felt heavier than action
would have.

She pulled her phone out one last time and
opened her notes.

She typed a single sentence, then stopped.
She added another.

Then she closed the app without saving.

Some things weren't ready to be named.

Not yet.

* * *

Added Scenes — Evening and After

Dinner happened anyway.

Allison sat at the kitchen table with a bowl of soup cooling in front of her, steam curling up in thin, wavering lines. Her mom moved around the kitchen, opening and closing cabinets without really needing anything from them, the way she did when she wanted to fill space with motion.

“You don’t have to eat it all,” her mom said, too casually.

“I know,” Allison replied, and took another spoonful to prove she was trying.

The soup tasted fine. Ordinary. Carrots too soft, broth a little salty. Allison focused on the sensation of swallowing, on the way her body accepted the food even if her mind didn’t want it.

Her mom sat across from her with a mug of tea, fingers wrapped around it like it was an anchor.

“Emily’s mom texted,” she said after a moment.

“She said things were... rough today.”

Allison’s spoon paused halfway to her mouth.

“Did she,” Allison said.

Her mom nodded. “I didn’t ask for details. I figured you’d tell me if you wanted to.”

Allison stared into the bowl. This was another opening. Not a trap—an invitation. Her mom was good at that. Leaving space without forcing her into it.

“I handled it,” Allison said finally.

Her mom studied her, eyes narrowing just a fraction. “That sounds like something someone says when they handled it by holding themselves together with duct tape.”

A short laugh escaped Allison before she could stop it. It surprised both of them.

“Fair,” Allison admitted.

Her mom’s mouth curved into a small smile.

“You don’t have to be strong all the time,” she said gently.

Allison nodded, because arguing would mean explaining. And she didn’t know how to explain the way strength had felt today—like a lid screwed down too tight.

After dinner, Allison helped rinse dishes, the warm water grounding her more than she expected. She lingered longer than necessary, watching bubbles gather and pop on the surface, reminding herself that things could still be simple.

Upstairs again, she closed her bedroom door and leaned her forehead against it for a second.

Her phone buzzed.

****Evan:**** didnt mean to dump that on you earlier

Allison stared at the message.

****Evan:**** just wanted you to know someone else saw it

She sat on the edge of her bed and typed slowly.

****Allison:**** saw what exactly

The reply didn’t come right away.

****Evan:**** not a thing. a pause. like the day hesitated

Allison’s chest tightened.

****Allison:**** thats not proof of anything

****Evan:**** i know. but its also not nothing

She considered not responding. Considered leaving the message unread and letting it sit there, unresolved.

Instead, she typed:

****Allison:**** please dont tell anyone

The typing bubble appeared almost immediately.

****Evan:**** i wouldnt. i know what it feels like
when people decide something about you without
asking

Allison closed her eyes.

****Allison:**** why are you being like this

A pause.

****Evan:**** because if i pretend i didnt notice, it
doesnt stop being true. it just means youre alone
with it

Her throat tightened. She didn't reply.

She set the phone down and lay back on her bed,
staring up at the ceiling fan as it turned slowly,
blades cutting the air into neat, predictable pieces.
She thought about the line again.

Not as a barrier, exactly—but as a choice that
existed now whether she wanted it to or not. A
place she could step toward or away from, but
never unknow.

She rolled onto her side and pulled the blanket up
around her shoulders.

She hadn't crossed the line.

But she could feel its shape in the dark.

And she knew, with a quiet certainty that settled
deep in her bones, that next time would not feel
the same.

* * *

Chapter 9 — The Shape of Attention

Allison started noticing patterns she didn't want to notice.

They showed up in small ways at first, easy to dismiss if she didn't look at them too closely. The way conversations stopped when she entered a room. The way people glanced at her and then at their phones, like they were checking something they weren't ready to talk about yet. The way Emily watched her now—not constantly, not obviously, but with a new sharpness, like she was waiting for Allison to slip.

Nothing had happened.

And yet, everything felt slightly misaligned, like the world had shifted a few inches to the left and never bothered to correct itself.

At school, the video was gone.

Officially.

The administration had sent out a carefully worded email about “inappropriate content” and “maintaining a respectful environment.” It didn't mention Kara by name. It didn't mention who had filmed it or who had shared it. It didn't mention consequences.

It didn't apologize.

Allison read the email twice during first period and felt almost nothing. That worried her more than anger would have.

Kara wasn't in class.

Emily slid into the seat beside Allison and dropped her bag with more force than necessary. “She's not coming in today,” she said quietly, eyes forward.

Allison's chest tightened. “Did she say why?”

Emily shook her head. “Just texted me that she couldn’t.”

The teacher cleared their throat and started talking, and the conversation ended there, unfinished. Allison stared at the board while dates and terms blurred together.

That was becoming another pattern too.

Between classes, Allison felt the attention more clearly. Not focused—diffuse. Like she’d become part of the background noise, except the background had learned her shape.

A sophomore she barely knew nodded at her in passing. A group of girls stopped laughing when she walked by, their smiles dissolving into something neutral. Someone whispered her name—not loudly enough to be certain, but not quietly enough to ignore.

Allison kept her head down.

She told herself she was imagining it.

She’d told herself that a lot lately.

At lunch, she sat with Emily but found herself watching the room instead of listening. Every raised phone made her pulse jump. Every burst of laughter felt like it might be aimed somewhere near her.

“You’re doing it again,” Emily said.

Allison blinked. “Doing what?”

“Scanning,” Emily said. “Like you’re waiting for something to explode.” She stabbed at her salad with unnecessary violence. “Relax. The drama cycle’s already moving on.”

Allison wanted to believe her.

“What if it doesn’t?” she asked quietly.

Emily shrugged. “Then something else happens and people forget. That’s how this works.”

Allison stared at her tray. “That’s not comforting.”

Emily sighed. “Okay, yeah. Fair.” She hesitated. “You okay though? Like... actually?”

Allison thought about the line. About the pressure in the hallway. About Evan noticing.

“I don’t know,” she said.

Emily studied her face. “That’s a new answer.”

After lunch, Allison found Evan by the lockers near the science wing.

She hadn’t meant to. She was just walking, letting the current carry her, and then he was there—leaning against the wall with his phone in his hands, like he’d been waiting without wanting to look like he was.

He noticed her at the same time she noticed him.

“Oh,” he said.

“Hey,” Allison replied.

They stood there awkwardly as students streamed past them, the noise filling the space where conversation should have been.

“I didn’t mean to corner you,” Evan said finally.

“I just... wanted to check in. In person.”

Allison nodded. “Okay.”

He glanced around, then gestured toward the quieter stretch of hallway leading toward the library. “You want to walk?”

She hesitated, then nodded.

They moved side by side, not touching, not quite in sync.

“I’m not here to ask questions,” Evan said quickly, like he was afraid she’d turn around and leave. “I just wanted you to know I haven’t said anything.”

“I know,” Allison said. “Thank you.”

Evan’s shoulders relaxed a fraction. “Good.”

They walked in silence for a few seconds.

"It's weird," Evan said eventually. "Seeing how fast things turn into... stories."

"You mean rumors," Allison said.

"Yeah. But also more than that." He frowned, searching for words. "It's like people decide what you are, and then they start looking for proof."

Allison's chest tightened. "What are they deciding about me?"

Evan hesitated. "I don't think they know yet."

That answer was somehow worse.

They reached the library doors. Evan stopped.

"I should go," he said. "I just wanted to say that."

"Okay."

He lingered. "If you notice things getting... heavier, let me know. Sometimes having a second pair of eyes helps."

Allison studied him. He wasn't offering solutions. He wasn't pretending to understand. He was just present.

"I will," she said, surprised to realize she meant it.

The rest of the day passed in fragments.

A teacher paused before calling on her, then chose someone else. A classmate asked her for help with a problem they could have solved themselves. Emily laughed at a joke that Allison hadn't heard.

When the final bell rang, Allison felt an unexpected rush of relief. She packed her bag quickly and slipped out before Emily could suggest hanging out.

She didn't want company.

She took the long way home.

The path by the creek was quiet, the air cool and damp. Allison walked slowly, letting her thoughts

catch up to her steps.

She stopped near the water and crouched, staring at the surface.

Nothing moved.

She wasn't testing anything. She told herself that firmly. She was just paying attention.

She thought about attention—how it gathered, how it shaped things. How being seen could change you even if no one touched you.

A ripple spread across the creek, starting from a point she couldn't see.

Allison's breath caught.

She straightened slowly.

The water settled again, smooth and reflective.

She laughed under her breath, shaky. "Get it together," she muttered.

But her heart kept racing.

At home, her mom was at the kitchen table, sorting mail.

"You walk again?" her mom asked.

"Yeah."

Her mom nodded. "Good. Clears your head."

Allison wasn't sure if that was true.

Upstairs, she sat on her bed and pulled out her phone.

A notification waited.

****Evan:**** you home okay?

She stared at it, then typed back.

****Allison:**** yeah.

A moment passed.

****Evan:**** good.

She set the phone down.

For the first time since everything started, Allison felt something shift—not outward, but inward. A sense that she was no longer just reacting. That she was beginning to understand the shape of the

pressure around her.

It wasn't power.

It was attention.

And once attention found you, it didn't let go
easily.

* * *

Authority Hesitation

The pause happened in third period.

It was small enough that no one else would have noticed it. Allison barely noticed it herself—except she was already tuned for it now, alert to the spaces where things didn't quite line up.

Her English teacher started to call on her. Allison saw it in the way her eyes flicked to the roster, the breath she took before speaking.

"Alli—"

The teacher stopped.

She glanced down again, then looked up at a different desk. "Mark. What do you think the author is trying to say here?"

Mark startled and scrambled for an answer.

Allison sat very still.

The teacher didn't look back at her. The class moved on. No one laughed. No one stared.

But the hesitation lingered like an echo.

Why did you stop? Allison wondered. *What were you about to ask me?*

The thought unsettled her more than if she'd been called on and gotten it wrong.

At the end of class, the teacher caught Allison's eye as students packed up.

"Allison," she said, gentle. "Could you stay a second?"

Allison's stomach dropped.

Everyone else filtered out. The room emptied until it was just the two of them and the faint hum of the lights.

"I just wanted to check in," the teacher said.

"You've seemed a little... distracted lately."

“I’m fine,” Allison said automatically.
The teacher smiled, but it didn’t quite reach her eyes. “I know things have been stressful for some students recently.”

Allison waited.

“If you ever need extra time on assignments,” the teacher continued, “or want to talk to the counselor—”

“I don’t,” Allison said, too quickly.

The teacher paused, then nodded. “Okay.”

She hesitated, then added, “You’re a good student. I just didn’t want you to feel overlooked.”

Overlooked.

Allison nodded, thanked her, and left the room with her heart pounding.

It wasn’t concern that bothered her.

It was the adjustment.

* * *

Failed Normalcy

After school, Emily tried to pretend everything was fine.

She linked her arm through Allison's as they walked down the front steps. "Ice cream?" she asked brightly. "We deserve it."

Allison hesitated. She could picture it easily—sitting on the low brick wall outside the shop, spooning sugar into her mouth until the day dulled.

"Sure," she said.

They walked together, talking about nothing. A substitute teacher who smelled like cigarettes. A quiz everyone bombed. Emily laughed loud and often, like she was determined to fill every quiet space before it could grow teeth.

At the shop, they ordered and sat.

Allison took one bite.

The sweetness made her stomach twist.

She tried another. Same result.

"You don't like it?" Emily asked, already halfway through her cone.

"I do," Allison lied.

Emily watched her. "You're doing the thing again."

"What thing?"

"Going somewhere else," Emily said. "You look like you're listening for something I can't hear."

Allison swallowed. "I'm just tired."

Emily's smile faltered. "You don't have to be on all the time, you know."

Allison almost laughed.

They finished in silence.

By the time they parted ways, Allison felt worse than she had before.

Normal didn't fit anymore.

* * *

Liminal Pressure

Allison returned to the creek as the sky began to darken.

She told herself she was only walking. Only clearing her head.

The path felt different now—not altered, just... attentive. Like it remembered her.

She stopped at the edge of the water.

The air pressed close. Sounds dulled, then sharpened again. The creek reflected the sky too clearly, like a mirror held at the wrong angle.

Allison's heart began to race.

She felt the pressure gather—not hot, not loud. Focused.

Don't, she told herself.

Her hands curled into fists.

For a moment, the world seemed to tilt toward her, waiting.

Allison stepped back.

The pressure loosened immediately, snapping away like a rubber band released.

The creek rippled, then stilled.

Allison stood there shaking.

She hadn't crossed the line.

She hadn't even reached for it.

But it had responded anyway.

That was new.

* * *

Direction

That night, Allison lay awake listening to the house settle.

She thought about the teacher's hesitation.

Emily's forced cheer. Evan's quiet attention. The creek waiting.

It wasn't power that scared her.

It was focus.

If attention gathered around her whether she wanted it to or not, then pretending nothing was happening wasn't protection.

It was delay.

Allison stared at the ceiling.

She didn't know what she would do yet.

She only knew she couldn't keep pretending nothing was happening.

* * *

Chapter 10 — Choosing the Shape of Silence

Allison stopped pretending that nothing was happening.

That decision didn't arrive all at once. It came in fragments, in the accumulation of small moments that refused to be ignored—the teacher's hesitation, Emily's forced cheer, Evan's quiet watching, the creek responding when she stepped back instead of forward.

Pretending required effort now.

And effort implied intention.

She noticed it first in the mornings.

She woke before her alarm, heart already alert, mind already scanning. Not for danger exactly—just for **difference**. She moved more carefully through her routine, aware of how often she adjusted herself without thinking. Her tone. Her posture. The speed of her steps.

Normal had become something she performed.

At school, she began to choose where she sat.

Not dramatically. Not in ways that would draw attention. Just small adjustments—corners instead of centers, empty seats instead of clusters. She listened more than she spoke. Watched who watched her.

Attention, she'd learned, was a current. You didn't have to fight it. You just had to decide how much of yourself to put into it.

Emily noticed.

"You're being weird again," Emily said at lunch, but her tone lacked accusation this time.

Allison glanced up. "How so?"

“You’re quiet on purpose,” Emily said. “That’s different from just being quiet.”

Allison considered that. “Is it bad?”

Emily shrugged. “I don’t know. It’s just... new.”

She hesitated. “You okay?”

Allison met her gaze. “I’m figuring things out.”

Emily studied her for a long moment, then nodded. “Okay.”

It wasn’t permission. But it was acceptance.

Kara returned midweek.

She moved through the halls like she was braced for impact, shoulders tight, hood up even when teachers told her to take it down. People pretended not to look. Which meant they were looking anyway.

Allison didn’t rush to her.

That choice hurt.

She wanted to. Every instinct screamed to close the distance, to anchor Kara with proximity. But she had learned something important: closeness carried weight now. Attention gathered where she stood.

So she waited.

When Kara finally found her—near the lockers after last period—it felt deliberate.

“You avoiding me?” Kara asked, voice flat.

Allison shook her head. “No. I didn’t want to make it worse.”

Kara’s mouth twisted. “By existing?”

“By pulling more eyes,” Allison said honestly.

Kara studied her. “You sound like you’ve thought about this.”

“I have.”

They stood there for a moment, the hallway emptying around them.

“I hate this,” Kara said finally.

“I know.”

Kara exhaled. “Rachel’s parents are furious. Not at her. At the school. Like this is censorship or something.”

Allison’s jaw tightened. “Of course they are.”

Kara watched her face. “You look different.”

Allison’s pulse jumped. “Different how?”

“Like you’re standing on something,” Kara said slowly. “Like you decided where to put your feet.”

Allison didn’t answer.

Kara nodded once, as if that was answer enough.

“Just... don’t disappear, okay?”

“I won’t,” Allison said.

But she didn’t promise closeness.

That afternoon, Evan walked with her.

Not because they planned it. Because they kept ending up in the same places, orbiting the same edges of things.

“You’re quieter,” Evan said.

“So are you,” Allison replied.

He smiled faintly. “Fair.”

They walked in companionable silence until Evan spoke again. “You’ve changed how you move.”

Allison shot him a look. “You track that?”

“I notice patterns,” Evan said. “Occupational hazard.”

“What occupation?”

“Being invisible,” he said lightly.

She considered that. “You’re not invisible.”

“Most of the time,” he said. “But you are now.”

Allison stopped walking.

Evan stopped too.

“That’s not—” she began, then paused.

Evan waited.

“I’m not trying to be,” Allison said finally.

“I know,” Evan said. “That’s why it works.”
The words settled uncomfortably.
They parted ways without ceremony.
That evening, Allison returned to the creek.
Not because she needed answers. Because she
needed *context*.
She stayed on the path this time, hands shoved
deep in her jacket pockets. The air was cool, the
sky heavy with clouds that hadn’t decided
whether to rain.
She stood still.
She didn’t reach.
The world felt closer anyway.
Not louder. Not brighter. Just... attentive. Like
the space around her had learned her outline.
Her heartbeat slowed.
She breathed.
Nothing happened.
And yet, something had changed.
She realized then that whatever this was didn’t
require action to exist. It didn’t need her
permission. It responded to *awareness*.
Which meant the real choice wasn’t whether to
use it.
It was whether to let it use her.
At home, her mom noticed the change too.
“You seem steadier,” she said over dinner.
“Quieter.”
Allison stirred her food. “Is that bad?”
Her mom smiled gently. “No. Just different.” She
hesitated. “Are you okay?”
Allison considered the question carefully.
“I think I am,” she said. “I just need to be
careful.”
Her mom reached across the table and squeezed
her hand. “You don’t have to do everything

alone.”

Allison squeezed back. “I know.”

That night, she wrote things down.

Not explanations. Not theories. Observations.

Places feel different when I pay attention.

People react before they know why.

Stepping back changes the pressure.

She didn’t label them. Labels felt dangerous.

She closed the notebook and slid it under her bed.

The next day at school, she tested something small.

She chose not to intervene.

Rachel laughed loudly in the hallway, telling a story that made a few people uncomfortable. The old pull rose in Allison’s chest—the urge to step in, to correct, to stop.

She didn’t.

The moment passed.

No ripple. No pressure.

The choice left a sour taste in her mouth, but it also clarified something important: restraint was not the same as helplessness. It was a decision.

Later, she *did* step in.

A freshman was being cornered near the vending machines, voices sharp, laughter edged with cruelty. Allison felt the familiar tightening—but this time she adjusted her position instead of charging forward. She placed herself where she could be seen without speaking.

The laughter faltered.

Someone muttered something and walked away.

Allison didn’t say a word.

The pressure ebbed.

Her hands shook afterward.

Not fear. Release.

Emily found her a few minutes later. “You good?”

Allison nodded. “Yeah.”

Emily studied her. “You didn’t even say anything.”

“I didn’t need to,” Allison said.

Emily laughed softly. “You’re terrifying sometimes.”

Allison smiled, thin and careful.

That evening, Evan texted her.

****Evan:**** you did something today

Allison stared at the message.

****Allison:**** i stood somewhere

A pause.

****Evan:**** exactly

She didn’t reply.

She didn’t need to.

By the time Allison went to bed, she understood something fundamental.

Silence wasn’t absence.

It was shape.

And choosing it—deliberately, carefully—was the first real decision she’d made since everything began.

* * *

The First Rule That Holds

The next morning, Allison wrote a rule in her head before she even left the house.

Not a sentence. Not a label. Just an instruction, the way you told yourself *don't touch the stove* when you knew it was hot.

Don't push. Don't pull. Just place yourself and watch what shifts.

It felt ridiculous to think of herself in rules.

It also felt necessary.

School was loud, bright, full of moving parts that didn't care about her internal logistics. Allison let herself blend into it. She walked the same hallways. Opened the same locker. Smiled when someone said hi. She kept her shoulders down, her breathing even, her face neutral.

And she listened.

Rachel was at the center of a small group near the trophy case, talking with the kind of confidence that made other people laugh even when the story wasn't funny. Allison kept her eyes on her locker dial and tried to pretend she didn't hear.

Then she heard Kara's name.

It wasn't shouted. It didn't have to be.

Rachel's voice dipped into that careful, sweet cruelty that sounded like a compliment until you realized it wasn't.

Allison felt the familiar tightening in her chest.

The urge.

She didn't move toward it.

She moved *around* it.

She shut her locker and walked past the trophy case without stopping. She didn't look at Rachel. She didn't look at Kara, who wasn't even there.

She didn't confront. She didn't correct.
She simply chose a path that put her in Rachel's
line of sight for a single beat—close enough to be
noticed, calm enough to not be readable.
Rachel's voice stuttered.
Just a fraction. A missed step.
The laughter around her faltered, confused by the
pause. Rachel recovered quickly, but the story
had lost its grip.
Allison kept walking.
Her heart pounded, but her hands were steady.
Rule one, she thought, surprised by the clarity.
Presence changes the current.

* * *

The Cost of Restraint

By lunch, the cost showed up.

Kara appeared at the edge of the cafeteria like she wasn't sure she was allowed to exist inside it. Her hood was down today, which should have been a victory. Instead it made her look exposed.

Allison spotted her immediately.

Emily did too. She nudged Allison with her elbow. "She's here," she murmured.

Allison's first instinct was to stand up. To wave Kara over. To close the distance fast so it couldn't be filled by someone else.

She stopped herself.

The rule in her head pulled tight.

Don't pull. Don't make a scene. Don't gather eyes.

Allison waited. She watched Kara scan the room, shoulders tense, hands clenched on her tray.

Rachel's table was laughing again, louder than necessary. Kara's gaze flicked toward it and away like it burned.

Allison stood anyway.

Not fast. Not dramatic.

She walked to Kara without waving, without calling her name. She stopped beside her, close enough to be unmistakable, and said quietly, "Come sit."

Kara's eyes widened. "I—"

"Just come," Allison said, gentle but firm.

Kara followed her back to the table.

Emily scooted over without comment.

For a few minutes, it worked. Kara ate a few bites. Emily talked about a quiz. Allison nodded at the right places.

Then someone behind them snickered.
A whisper drifted: "That's her."
Kara's shoulders went rigid. Her fork stopped
midway to her mouth.
Allison felt the tightening again, immediate. The
urge to turn, to stare, to make the whisperer regret
having a mouth.
She didn't.
She kept her eyes on Kara and said softly,
"Breathe."
Kara's breath hitched.
Allison's own breath stayed steady even as her
pulse roared.
The whisperers didn't stop because Allison
restrained herself. They stopped because they got
bored, because the moment didn't feed them
back.
But Kara didn't relax. Her eyes stayed shiny,
fixed on a spot on the table like she was holding
herself together by force.
After lunch, Kara walked out without saying
goodbye.
Emily watched her go. "That sucked," she said.
Allison nodded. The sour taste rose again.
Restraint protected her from exploding.
It didn't protect Kara from being hurt.

* * *

Pressure From Above

Fourth period, Allison's name came over the intercom.

"Allison Mercer, please report to the counseling office."

The classroom went still for a second, then resumed breathing.

Allison stood slowly.

Emily's eyes flicked up from her notebook, sharp.

Allison gave her a look that said *don't*.

She walked down the hallway alone.

The counseling office smelled like lavender and printer toner. A bowl of peppermints sat on the counter, untouched. The secretary smiled too widely.

"Hi, Allison. Just have a seat," she said.

Allison sat in a chair that was deliberately comfortable.

The counselor—Ms. Harper—called her back a moment later. The office was warm, decorated with motivational posters that felt vaguely threatening in their cheerfulness.

Ms. Harper gestured to a chair. "Thanks for coming down," she said. "How are you feeling today?"

Allison kept her face neutral. "Fine."

Ms. Harper nodded like she'd expected that answer. "There's been some... social stress lately," she said carefully. "We're checking in with a few students to make sure everyone has support."

Allison's fingers curled around the armrest.

"Is this about the video?" Allison asked.

"In part," Ms. Harper said. "But also about you."

Allison's chest tightened.

Ms. Harper smiled gently. "Your teachers have mentioned you seem... very alert lately."

Allison held her gaze. "I'm tired."

"Mm," Ms. Harper said, not quite believing.

"Sometimes when people experience stress, they become hypervigilant. It's a protective response."

Allison swallowed. "Okay."

Ms. Harper leaned forward a fraction. "If you need someone to talk to—about anything—you can come here. No judgement."

Allison nodded, because refusing would create friction.

Ms. Harper's tone softened further. "And if you ever feel like you're carrying responsibility that isn't yours—"

Allison's throat tightened.

"That's not—" she started, then stopped. She could feel the line in her mind, the shape of it. If she spoke too much, she would cross it.

"I'm okay," she said again.

Ms. Harper watched her for a long moment.

Then she nodded. "All right. Just... remember you have options."

Options.

Allison left the office feeling like she'd been gently placed under glass.

* * *

Private Acknowledgment

That night, Allison opened her notebook again.
Not her phone notes. Not the safe, erasable
screen. The notebook felt more real. More
dangerous.

She wrote three lines, neat and controlled:

Presence changes things.

Restraint has a cost.

Adults notice patterns too.

She stared at the page until the words stopped
looking like hers.

Then, at the bottom, she wrote something she
hadn't allowed herself to write before.

*This isn't happening to me anymore. I'm
participating.*

Her hand shook as she underlined it once, hard
enough to dent the paper.

She closed the notebook and slid it under her bed,
like hiding it would make it less true.

Her phone buzzed.

Evan: you got called to counseling?

Allison's breath caught. She stared at the
message.

Allison: how do you know

A pause.

Evan: saw you walk in. didnt want to follow.
just... noticed.

Allison swallowed.

Allison: im fine

Evan: okay. but if theyre starting to watch
you, be careful

Allison's chest tightened.

Allison: you make it sound like a thing

A pause longer than usual.

****Evan:**** it is a thing. you just get to choose
what kind

Allison stared at that sentence until her eyes
burned.

She set the phone down and turned off her lamp.

In the dark, she could still feel the shape of
silence she'd chosen today.

Not absence.

Not weakness.

A strategy.

And strategies, she realized, created new
problems.

Because once you chose a shape, the world
learned to press against it.

* * *

Chapter 11 — Breakdown Without Collapse

The first thing Allison noticed was the quiet. Not the absence of noise — the school was still loud, still full of lockers slamming and voices overlapping and someone laughing too hard at something unfunny — but the absence of reaction.

Nothing had exploded.

No announcements had been made. No teachers were whispering in corners. No one was crying in the bathroom, at least not where Allison could hear them.

The world had not cracked open.

It had absorbed the impact and kept going.

That scared her more than if it had broken.

Allison stood near her locker longer than necessary, fingers resting on the cool metal, trying to orient herself. The video had already been shared. That part was done. The damage had already spread in ways she couldn't track or pull back.

She could feel it now — that familiar pressure behind her eyes, the sensation of something coiling and waiting, like the moment before a storm that never quite arrived.

Her first instinct was still there.

Fix it.

Not loudly. Not dramatically.

Just enough.

She imagined the video glitching. Disappearing.

Becoming something people forgot how to open.

She imagined conversations losing their edge, laughter dulling, attention sliding away.

The images came easily.
Too easily.
Allison swallowed hard and forced herself to look away from the hallway, from the faces moving past her without seeing her.
She couldn't do that.
Not anymore.
Kara's voice came back to her with painful clarity — not raised, not angry, just steady.
Don't carry this for me.
Allison closed her eyes.
The pressure surged, sharp and insistent, like it resented being denied.
She breathed through it.
In. Out.
Slow.
Grounded.
When she opened her eyes again, the hallway was still there. The noise was still there. The world hadn't rearranged itself to accommodate her fear.
That, at least, was honest.

* * *

Kara didn't come to first period.
Her desk sat empty, notebook still tucked underneath, the edge of a pink cover just visible.
Allison kept glancing at it without meaning to, each look sending a small, sharp pulse through her chest.
The teacher paused at attendance.
Just for a second.
Then moved on.
That pause felt like a warning.
Or a mercy.
Allison wasn't sure which.
Emily leaned over once, whispering, "Have you heard from her?"

Allison shook her head.
Emily's mouth tightened. She didn't push.
That restraint — small, human, unmagical — felt
heavier than anything else that morning.
In English, Allison couldn't focus.
The words on the page blurred, sentences slipping
apart before she could finish them. Every time
someone shifted in their seat or murmured to a
neighbor, her attention snagged, alert and ready.
Waiting.
She hated that part of herself.
Hated how easily the world seemed to lean when
she noticed it.
At lunch, Kara's seat stayed empty.
People talked anyway.
Too loudly. Too carefully. Too normal.
Allison picked at her food, appetite gone, eyes
flicking constantly to the edges of the room. She
felt like she was standing in the center of
something fragile, afraid that one wrong
movement would shatter it.
Emily finally sighed and said, "You're going to
make yourself sick if you keep staring like that."
Allison looked down at her tray. "I'm fine."
Emily didn't look convinced.

* * *

After school, Allison found Kara by the bike
racks.
She almost didn't recognize her at first —
shoulders hunched, hair pulled back too tight,
eyes fixed on the ground like it might open up
and swallow her.
"Kara," Allison said softly.
Kara flinched.
That hurt more than anything else that day.
"Oh," Kara said, glancing up. "Hey."

They stood there awkwardly, the late afternoon sun slanting across the pavement, dust motes drifting in the light.

"I'm sorry," Allison said immediately. "I should have— I mean, I didn't—"

Kara shook her head. "No."

The word was quiet but firm.

Allison stopped.

Kara looked tired. Not dramatic tired. Just... worn thin. Like she'd spent the day holding herself together with effort alone.

"You can't fix this," Kara said, like she was stating a fact, not issuing a challenge. "And I don't want you to try."

Allison's chest tightened. "I just don't want you to—"

"To disappear?" Kara finished.

Allison didn't answer.

Kara sighed. "I need to handle this myself. If you do something — if you change things — it won't feel real anymore. It'll feel like I didn't get to choose what happened to me."

The words landed heavy and final.

Allison nodded slowly. "Okay."

Kara studied her face, like she was looking for cracks. "You mean that?"

Allison swallowed. "Yeah."

That was the moment.

Not when the video spread.

Not when the rumors started.

That was the moment everything actually broke.

Kara's shoulders relaxed just a fraction. "Good."

She picked up her bike. "I'll see you," she said, not unkindly.

Then she left.

Allison stood there long after she was gone, the pressure still thrumming behind her eyes, still offering solutions she refused to take.

She felt hollow.

But she also felt... intact.

* * *

That night, Allison lay awake staring at the ceiling.

She thought about everything she could have done and hadn't.

The fixes she'd imagined.

The control she'd let go.

The pressure stirred, restless and unsatisfied.

Allison turned onto her side and pressed her face into the pillow, grounding herself in the weight of her own body.

She hadn't stopped the damage.

But she hadn't erased Kara either.

The world remained broken.

And she had chosen — deliberately — not to mend it by force.

For the first time, Allison understood that restraint wasn't the absence of action.

It was a decision.

One she would have to keep making.

* * *

Chapter 12 — What She Doesn't End

The school day started like nothing had happened.

That was the first lie.

The second was that it would feel better once things settled.

Allison stood at the edge of the parking lot before the first bell, backpack hanging heavy from one shoulder, watching students stream toward the building in familiar clusters. Laughter rose and fell. Someone shouted a name across the lot. A car horn blared too long and got yelled at.

Everything looked normal.

Everything felt wrong.

Kara wasn't there.

That absence hit Allison in waves, each one shaped differently. Sometimes it was sharp, a sudden realization that made her chest tighten. Sometimes it was dull, like her body had already adjusted and that adjustment felt like a betrayal. She followed Emily inside, the crowd swallowing them up.

The hallways were loud. Lockers slammed. Someone bumped into Allison's shoulder without apologizing. Another student laughed too hard at something on their phone, then stopped when a teacher passed.

The noise felt different today.

Not heavier.

Looser.

Like something important had slipped out of alignment and everyone was compensating without knowing why.

Allison could feel it — that faint pressure behind her eyes, the sense of moments leaning toward her, expectant.

She kept her attention low.

Kept her breathing steady.

Kept herself small.

* * *

Homeroom confirmed it.

Kara's desk was gone.

Not moved to the back. Not stacked with extras.

Gone.

The space it left behind felt louder than the chatter filling the room. Allison stared at it, heart pounding, waiting for someone to comment.

No one did.

The teacher began attendance without hesitation, her voice smooth and practiced.

Names were called.

Hands went up.

Responses came back automatic.

Kara's name never arrived.

The absence of that pause — the brief moment where the teacher usually glanced at the empty chair and frowned — landed harder than Allison expected. It felt like watching a sentence skip a word and still make sense.

Emily leaned over, her voice barely audible.

"They really did it."

Allison nodded.

Her throat felt too tight to speak.

The lesson started. Notes were taken. A worksheet was passed down the row.

Life moved forward like it always did.

Allison pressed her fingers into the edge of her desk until the pressure steadied her.

Don't reach.

Don't fill the space.

Let it exist.

* * *

By second period, the rumors had started.

They moved quietly, carefully, like people knew they were handling something fragile.

"She transferred," someone said near the lockers, voice low but eager.

"No, she got pulled out," someone else replied.

"Her parents."

"I heard it was mental health stuff. Like, serious."

Each version sounded reasonable.

Each version felt wrong.

Allison passed through them like a ghost, her name never attached to the conversation but her presence changing the tone anyway. Voices dipped when she drew near. Words shifted.

Sentences ended early.

That was new.

She hated it.

In math, the boy behind her kept whispering to his friend. Allison caught fragments — video, trouble, shouldn't have shared — before the teacher snapped at them to pay attention.

Allison's chest tightened.

She could feel the pressure gathering, a familiar sensation that came with the urge to intervene.

Not loudly. Not dramatically.

Just enough to make it stop.

She stared down at her paper instead.

The whispering faded on its own, replaced by tapping pencils and restless sighs.

Allison's hands were shaking.

She forced them still.

* * *

Third period brought the confrontation she'd been dreading.

Rachel.

She was leaning against a locker near the science wing, arms crossed, posture relaxed in a way that felt calculated. She didn't look surprised to see Allison.

"Hey," Rachel said, tone casual. "Got a minute?"

Allison stopped walking.

Emily slowed beside her, eyes flicking between them.

"I'm going to class," Emily muttered, not quite meeting Allison's gaze. "I'll see you later."

She disappeared down the hall, leaving Allison standing alone with Rachel and the hum of passing students.

"What do you want," Allison asked.

Rachel raised an eyebrow. "Still sharp. Guess some things don't change."

Allison didn't respond.

Rachel's gaze flicked down the hall, then back.

"You know this is kind of your fault, right."

The words hit like a slap.

Allison felt the pressure spike, sharp and immediate.

Rachel kept going, her voice low. "If you hadn't made such a big deal about it, maybe things wouldn't have blown up the way they did."

Allison's vision narrowed.

She could feel the moment tipping — the way Rachel leaned in just slightly, the way the hallway noise seemed to recede.

The pressure surged.

Allison imagined Rachel's voice faltering.

Imagined her losing momentum, backing off, suddenly unsure.

The sensation was intoxicating.

Terrifying.

Allison took a step back instead.

“No,” she said, her voice steady with effort.

“That’s not true.”

Rachel blinked. “What.”

“You shared it,” Allison said. “You don’t get to decide how it landed.”

Rachel’s mouth tightened. “Wow. So you’re just going to—”

“I’m done,” Allison said.

She turned and walked away before Rachel could respond, heart hammering.

The pressure lingered for a long moment, then faded.

Allison didn’t feel triumphant.

She felt wrung out.

* * *

At lunch, Kara’s table was occupied.

Allison stopped short, tray balanced in her hands, staring at the group of students laughing too loudly, backpacks piled carelessly on the seats.

They didn’t look malicious.

They looked unaware.

Emily appeared beside her. “We don’t have to sit there.”

“I know,” Allison said.

They turned away together, choosing a corner table instead.

They ate mostly in silence.

Emily picked at her fries. “I texted her again,” she said quietly. “Still nothing.”

Allison nodded.

“She might not want to talk,” Emily added, like she needed to say it out loud to make it real.

“I know,” Allison said.

The cafeteria noise swelled around them — trays clattering, voices overlapping, someone laughing at a joke Allison couldn't hear.

Life, again, insisting on itself.

Allison felt the pressure stir faintly, then settle.

She kept eating.

* * *

By the end of the day, Allison felt hollowed out.

Not empty.

Used.

Like she'd spent the entire day holding something heavy just out of sight.

She walked home alone, choosing the long way without consciously deciding to.

The creek appeared ahead, water moving steadily over stones.

Allison stopped at the edge, staring down at the surface.

The water didn't ask anything of her.

It didn't wait.

It just moved.

She stood there for a long time, hands shoved deep into her jacket sleeves, feeling the pressure ebb and flow without acting on it.

Not fixing.

Not erasing.

Just... not ending it.

At home, her mom asked how school was.

"Fine," Allison said.

Her mom watched her for a moment, then nodded. "Okay."

That word again.

Always okay.

Never tell me.

That night, Allison lay awake, staring at the ceiling.

She thought about everything she hadn't done
that day.
The arguments she'd let play out.
The rumors she'd walked past.
The confrontation she'd ended without smoothing
over.
It felt wrong.
It also felt necessary.
The pressure stirred faintly behind her eyes.
Not sharp.
Not demanding.
Just present.
Waiting.
Allison turned onto her side and closed her eyes,
holding onto one small, fragile certainty.
She hadn't fixed anything.
But she hadn't broken it either.
And for now, that was enough.

* * *

Chapter 13 — Interlude: Aftermath

The incident was addressed.

That was the language used.

Not resolved.

Not understood.

Not harmful.

Addressed.

A meeting was held behind closed doors. Notes were taken. A decision was recorded. The timeline was shortened until it fit neatly into a single line on a report.

An event occurred.

An intervention followed.

The matter was concluded.

The school sent out an email to parents that afternoon.

It emphasized safety.

It emphasized community values.

It emphasized that appropriate steps had been taken.

No names were mentioned.

In the days that followed, the building adjusted.

Attendance lists updated automatically. Seating charts were revised. Teachers were instructed to be flexible, though no guidance was given on what flexibility should look like in practice.

Some were lenient.

Some were not.

Counselors kept their doors open longer. A box of tissues appeared on a side table. A poster about resilience was taped to the wall where the edges curled slightly, like it hadn't been pressed down long enough to stay.

Students were reminded about digital responsibility.

Assemblies were scheduled.

The focus was forward-looking.

There were no formal acknowledgments of loss.

There was no collective pause.

The hallways absorbed the change the way they always did — quietly, unevenly, with certain corners carrying more weight than others.

Some students spoke in whispers for a few days, voices dipping when teachers passed. Others joked too loudly, relief curdling into noise. A few asked careful questions and received vague answers in return.

Eventually, most stopped asking.

The absence remained.

It lived in the gaps between lockers. In the chair that was no longer there. In the way conversations shifted without anyone consciously deciding to change them.

The system preferred this version of events.

Contained.

Documented.

Closed.

By the end of the week, the incident was no longer considered active.

It existed only in records, filed away under language that suggested order had been restored. From the outside, it appeared that nothing had broken.

From the inside, something essential had been quietly removed.

And the structure, satisfied with its response, moved on.

* * *

Chapter 14 — Someone They Lost

The town didn't talk about Kara.

That was the first thing Allison noticed.

Not in the careful way people avoided subjects they didn't know how to handle. Not in lowered voices or sympathetic looks or awkward pauses mid-sentence.

They just didn't say her name at all.

It wasn't avoidance so much as agreement — a quiet, collective decision that whatever had happened belonged to the past now, and the past didn't need to be revisited if everyone pretended it had resolved itself.

At school, the halls felt narrower.

Not physically. The lockers still lined the walls in dull, dented rows. The floors were still scuffed and polished into the same tired shine. But people moved differently, paths curving around empty spaces like water avoiding a crack.

Kara's desk was gone by Monday.

Not ceremoniously. Not announced.

Just... removed.

Allison noticed it the moment she walked into homeroom. The chair, the desk, the small carved initials along the edge — all gone. In their place was a clean patch of floor that felt louder than anything else in the room.

No one commented.

The teacher didn't pause attendance this time.

The list had been updated.

Allison felt the loss of that pause more sharply than she expected. The silence where Kara's name should have been felt heavier than hearing it ever had.

Emily sat beside her, jaw tight, staring straight ahead.

"They moved it," Emily muttered, barely moving her lips.

Allison nodded once.

She didn't trust her voice.

The notebook was gone too. The pink cover. The peeling sticker. Any proof that Kara had occupied that space for months, leaning back in her chair, tapping her pen against the desk when she was bored.

It was efficient.

It was cruel.

By third period, people had started filling the silence with substitutes.

"She transferred, right?" someone whispered near the lockers.

"I heard it was family stuff."

"No, it was mental health. Like... serious."

Each version was quieter than the last, shaped to sound responsible. Concerned. Reasonable.

Allison hated them all.

She hated how easily Kara became a rumor instead of a person.

Rachel didn't say anything.

That was almost worse.

Rachel passed Allison in the hall once, their shoulders brushing just barely, and kept walking without comment. No smirk. No remark. No sideways glance.

It felt deliberate.

Like a truce that hadn't been negotiated.

In English class, the teacher handed back essays.

"Allison," she said, offering a small smile that didn't reach her eyes. "If you need an extension on the next assignment, just let me know."

Allison took the paper, heat flushing her face.
“I’m fine.”

The teacher nodded like she’d expected that answer. “Okay.”

That word again.

Always okay.

Never tell me.

At lunch, Kara’s old table had been claimed.

Not by anyone Allison recognized well — a group of freshmen, laughing too loudly, backpacks slung over chairs with careless confidence.

They didn’t know.

Or maybe they did, and it didn’t matter.

Allison stopped short when she saw it, tray balanced in her hands.

Emily hesitated beside her. “We don’t have to sit there.”

“I know,” Allison said.

She turned away before she could decide whether she was angry or relieved.

They ate somewhere else.

Again.

The cafeteria noise rose and fell like surf, indifferent and unbothered.

After school, Allison walked past the creek.

She slowed without meaning to.

The water moved steadily, sliding over stones that hadn’t changed shape just because something nearby had. Leaves drifted along the surface, caught briefly, then released.

She stood at the edge for a long moment, hands shoved into her jacket sleeves, and thought about all the times Kara had kicked rocks into the water just to watch the ripples.

Allison didn’t step closer.

She didn't trust what she might feel if she did.
At home, her mom was on the phone when
Allison came in.

"Yes, I know," she was saying, voice low. "I just
worry about her. She doesn't talk much."

Allison froze in the doorway.

Her mom glanced up, startled, then covered the
receiver. "I'll call you back."

She hung up and turned fully toward Allison.

"Hey."

Allison shrugged. "Hey."

Her mom studied her face. "How are you holding
up?"

Allison stared at the floor. "Fine."

Her mom sighed softly. "You don't have to be."

Allison swallowed. "I don't know what else to
be."

That seemed to catch her mom off guard.

She reached out, then stopped, hand hovering
awkwardly before dropping back to her side. "If
you want to talk—"

"I don't," Allison said, too quickly.

Her mom nodded, accepting the boundary with
visible effort. "Okay."

There it was again.

That night, Allison lay awake listening to the hum
of the house.

She thought about Kara not as she was now —
distant, unreachable — but as she had been.

Laughing in the creek. Rolling her eyes at bad
jokes. Leaning into Allison's shoulder without
thinking about it.

The memories felt fragile.

Like if Allison held them too tightly, they might
warp into something else.

She wondered if Kara was sleeping somewhere else, under a different ceiling, trying to convince herself she'd made the right choice.

She wondered if Kara felt like something had been lost — or if that feeling belonged only to the people left behind.

The pressure stirred faintly at the back of Allison's mind.

Not sharp.

Not demanding.

Just present.

The world, waiting for her to do something about the emptiness.

Allison turned onto her side and pressed her face into her pillow until the sensation faded.

She wasn't ready to be the person who decided what loss meant.

Not yet.

* * *

Chapter 15 — The Shape of Choosing

Nothing happened.

That was what unsettled Allison most.

The days kept arriving in their usual order.

Morning followed night. School followed morning. Homework followed dinner. The world didn't pause or stutter or acknowledge that anything had gone wrong. It just... continued.

Kara's absence had stopped being sharp.

It had smoothed into routine.

Allison noticed it in the way teachers no longer hesitated during attendance, the way classmates stopped lowering their voices when she walked past. Even Emily complained about homework again, like she used to, instead of circling silence with careful words.

Normal was returning.

And with it came a different kind of weight.

It wasn't the tight, urgent feeling she'd learned to fear. It was heavier than that. Quieter. Like something settling into place and daring her to pretend she didn't feel it.

One morning, Allison sat on the edge of her bed with her backpack at her feet and realized something that made her stomach twist.

The world had stopped waiting for her to act.

It had started assuming she wouldn't.

At school, she drifted between classes without really engaging. The hallways felt wider again, less brittle. People laughed. Someone dropped a stack of papers and swore. A substitute teacher asked for directions.

Life, insisting on itself.

Allison watched it like she was slightly out of sync, half a step behind everything else.

In biology, the group at the next table started arguing. Not yelling. Not cruel. Just the low, grinding friction of people talking past each other.

Normally, she would have felt it immediately—the tightening behind her eyes, the sense that the moment was leaning toward her, asking for something.

She felt that now.

Faint. Waiting.

Allison froze.

The argument sharpened. One voice went flat.

Another snapped back. The teacher glanced over.

Allison's breath caught.

She could make this stop.

Not fix it. Not solve it. Just... dull the edge. Let it pass without becoming something heavier.

Her attention brushed the moment, and the familiar pressure stirred.

Allison pulled back hard.

She forced herself to look down at her notebook, to trace the lines of a diagram she didn't care about, to stay where she was instead of leaning into the feeling.

The voices lowered on their own.

The argument fizzled out, awkward and incomplete.

Allison's hands were shaking.

She pressed them flat against the desk until they stopped.

That was new.

Not the feeling.

The choice.

Emily caught up with her after school, breathless and irritated.

“You’ve been weird,” she said, not unkindly.

Allison blinked. “I’ve always been weird.”

Emily snorted. “Different weird. You’re like... here, but not.”

Allison frowned. “I’m trying not to mess things up.”

Emily stopped walking.

“That’s not the same as doing nothing,” she said carefully.

Allison looked away. “It feels like it is.”

Emily studied her face for a long moment. “When you stop reacting,” she said quietly, “it kind of feels like you’re disappearing.”

The words landed harder than Emily probably meant them to.

“I’m still here,” Allison said, too fast.

“I know,” Emily said. “I just... want you to know that too.”

They walked the rest of the way without speaking.

Allison didn’t go to the creek.

She went to the field.

The bleachers were empty, metal cold under her palms as she sat. The grass bent in the wind without caring which direction it leaned.

Evan arrived a few minutes later, like he’d expected her.

He sat a few rows down, close enough to talk without crowding.

“You’ve been holding yourself very still,” he said after a while.

Allison huffed a breath. “Is it that obvious?”

“To someone who notices patterns,” Evan said.

“Yeah.”

She stared out at the field. "I'm scared that if I do anything, I'll make it worse."

Evan nodded. "That's possible."

Allison winced.

"But doing nothing isn't neutral," he added.

"I know," she said.

Evan tilted his head. "What do you think you're actually responsible for?"

Allison swallowed. "I don't know."

"Then maybe that's the wrong question," he said.

She turned to look at him. "What's the right one?"

"What are you willing to be responsible for?"

The question sat between them.

Allison felt the familiar pressure stir—not demanding, not sharp. Just present.

She thought about Kara. About the way fixing had started to feel like love and ended up feeling like control.

"I won't push on people," Allison said slowly. "I won't make things stop just because I want them to."

Evan nodded, like that mattered.

"I won't decide for them," she continued. "Even if I think I know better."

He watched her carefully.

"But I won't disappear either," Allison added. "I won't pretend I don't see things."

"That sounds survivable," Evan said.

Allison let out a shaky breath. "That's a low bar."

"Low bars keep you from falling," he said.

That night, Allison opened her notebook.

Not the one for school.

The other one.

She didn't write about Kara.

She didn't write about what she was afraid of.

She wrote a list.
Things I won't do.
Things I might.
Things I need to think about more.
The list was messy. Incomplete. Full of
crossed-out lines and half-thoughts.
It felt real.
When she closed the notebook, the pressure was
still there.
But it wasn't steering her.
She was.
For the first time since everything had broken
without collapsing, Allison felt something take
shape inside her.
Not certainty.
Direction.
And that was enough to keep moving.

* * *

Chapter 16 — The Choice That Remains

Allison knew what would happen.

Not in words. Not in images. Just in direction — the way a thing leaned before gravity finished the argument.

The hallway was too loud, but the sound felt thin, stretched, like it was skimming across the surface of something hollow. Lockers slammed. Shoes squeaked. Someone laughed sharply, then laughed again, louder, as if daring the noise to be questioned.

People were trying.

That was the strange part. Everyone was trying harder than usual. Smiling longer. Talking faster. Performing relief with the anxious precision of people who had been told, very clearly, that things were supposed to be better now.

Allison stood still long enough that foot traffic bent around her. Bodies adjusted instinctively, like water flowing around a rock. No one looked at her long enough to apologize. They didn't need to. The space itself discouraged lingering.

She felt like a gap — not visible, exactly, but influential. Something the room had learned to work around.

Near the windows at the end of the hall, a girl sat on the floor with her back against the lockers. Her knees were pulled tight to her chest, arms wrapped around them, chin tucked down as if she could fold herself into something smaller, something easier to ignore. Her hair fell forward, hiding most of her face.

Another girl hovered nearby, crouched awkwardly, whispering in quick bursts. Whatever

she was saying sounded urgent and useless at the same time. Comfort offered without confidence.

The crying wasn't loud.

That was what made it dangerous.

It stayed contained, trapped behind clenched teeth and shallow breaths. The kind of crying that didn't summon adults or draw crowds. The kind that waited patiently for permission to exist.

Allison watched the girl's hands shake as she wiped at her face. Watched her shoulders hitch, still, hitch again — like she was negotiating with her own lungs. People glanced as they passed, their eyes sliding away the moment recognition sparked.

Discomfort acknowledged.

Responsibility declined.

The bell rang.

The sound cracked through the hallway like a command.

Movement resumed. Students flowed around the girl. Someone stepped over her foot without noticing. A teacher called out for everyone to get to class, voice brisk, professional, relieved to have an excuse to redirect attention.

The hovering friend hesitated, torn, then stood and followed the current down the hall.

The girl stayed where she was.

Allison felt the pressure gather behind her eyes.

Not panic. Not fear.

Recognition.

The same tightness she'd felt before. The same sense of something unfinished, waiting to be pushed one way or another. A system under strain, seeking equilibrium.

The first time she'd felt it, she'd frozen.

She'd stood there while everything sharpened — emotions tightening, attention pulling inward, silence growing heavier by the second — until it collapsed on its own. The aftermath had been messy. Loud. Uncontrolled. She'd gone home shaking, sick with the knowledge that she'd been close to something and hadn't known what to do with it.

She'd told herself that doing nothing had been the right choice.

Standing there now, watching the girl on the floor struggle to breathe quietly enough to be allowed to stay, Allison knew that wasn't true.

In class, the girl sat three rows ahead of her. She didn't look back. Her posture was rigid, movements precise, as if she were afraid of disturbing the air. When the teacher handed out worksheets, her fingers fumbled, paper slipping once, twice, before she caught it and flattened it carefully on her desk.

The teacher didn't comment.

No one did.

The lesson moved forward. Instructions were given. Pens scratched against paper. The room settled into the familiar rhythm of compliance. Allison watched instead.

She watched the edges of the room. The way attention avoided anything uneven. The way discomfort was quietly escorted toward the exits and told it could return later, maybe, when it was less inconvenient.

This wasn't isolated.

It was spreading.

The girl erased the same word again and again, pencil wearing the paper thin. Her knee bounced under the desk. Her breathing stayed shallow,

clipped, like she was rationing air.

Something in the room wanted to end.

Not the class.

Not the day.

The tension.

Allison let herself feel it fully this time. The pull of it. The imbalance. The way everything leaned toward quiet, toward resolution, toward something that could be labeled “handled.”

She didn’t think about the girl’s name.

Didn’t think about what had already been lost.

Didn’t think about why this feeling was becoming familiar.

She focused on the shape.

And she didn’t resist it.

She allowed it.

The change was subtle. Almost polite.

The tightness eased, like a knot loosening without being untied. The air felt different — warmer, maybe, or lighter. Someone exhaled sharply, then laughed, surprised by the sound. The teacher glanced up, reassured by the sudden calm, and continued explaining the worksheet with renewed confidence.

The girl’s knee stopped bouncing.

Her shoulders dropped.

She took a deeper breath — the first real one Allison had seen her take all period. Her grip on the pencil loosened. Her eraser stayed still.

Relief moved through the room like a wave that left no trace.

It worked.

Allison felt it immediately — the smoothness of it, the way everything slid into place. The problem resolved itself without disruption or mess. No one needed to intervene. No one needed

to ask questions.

Too smooth.

By the end of class, the girl was smiling. Not brightly. Not happily. But convincingly enough that no one lingered on her. She packed up quickly, eyes down, and slipped out the door before the bell finished ringing.

Allison stayed in her seat.

Something was missing.

Not sadness.

Not pain.

Urgency.

The sharp edge that demanded attention had been dulled, filed down into something survivable.

Something manageable. Something that would not interrupt anyone else's day.

Whatever came next for the girl would come later. Quieter. Slower. Easier to overlook.

In the hallway, the school felt lighter. Easier. Like a system that had detected instability and corrected for it.

No one looked at Allison.

That was new.

She walked home with the uneasy sense that the ground beneath her feet had shifted — not enough to knock her over, but enough that she would never quite stand the same way again.

At dinner, her mother asked how school was, voice casual, already half-turned toward the stove.

"Fine," Allison said.

Her voice didn't shake.

Later, in her room, she lay on her bed with the lights off, phone warm in her hand. The ceiling fan ticked softly overhead. Outside, a car passed, music muffled, familiar.

She opened her Notes app and stared at the blank screen until her eyes burned.

When she typed, the words came clean and simple.

It stopped.

She stopped shaking.

Everyone was relieved.

I was too.

She waited for the need to explain.

For guilt.

For justification.

For something that would tell her how to feel.

Nothing came.

She locked the phone and set it face-down on the bed.

Outside, the town eased into evening. Porch lights flicked on. Doors closed. Someone laughed in a neighboring yard.

The day settled itself, neat and complete.

Allison stared at the ceiling, pulse steady, stomach hollow.

She knew what she had done.

And she knew something worse.

She would do it again.

Not because it felt right.

Because it worked.

* * *

Chapter 17 — What Stays Quiet

The next morning felt normal.

That was the problem.

Allison noticed it before she even opened her eyes — the absence of dread, the lack of resistance in her own body. No tightness in her chest. No racing thoughts. Just the dull weight of sleep giving way to routine.

The house woke the way it always did. Pipes clicked behind the walls. The coffee maker hummed. Her mother moved through the kitchen with practiced efficiency, already halfway into a day that did not include whatever Allison had shifted out of place.

“Don’t forget your lunch,” her mom said, sliding a paper bag across the counter without looking up.

Allison nodded and picked it up. The bag was warm from sitting near the stove. Solid. Familiar. It felt like proof — not that things were okay, but that they were continuing.

Outside, the air was cool and damp, clinging lightly to her skin. The street looked unchanged. Same cars parked at the same angles. Same lawns trimmed just enough to look intentional. Porch lights flicked off one by one as people left for work.

Alder Creek trusted its mornings.

That trust sat heavy in Allison’s chest as she walked.

At school, the hallways sounded right again.

Not loud.

Not hollow.

Balanced.

Students moved in easy clusters, backpacks slung low, conversations overlapping without urgency. Someone complained about a test. Someone else laughed too hard at a joke that wasn't funny. A teacher reminded everyone to keep moving, voice firm but unbothered.

The rhythm had returned.

Allison moved through it like an afterimage, searching without meaning to. Not for the girl from yesterday — she knew better than to look for that — but for evidence. A pause too long. A voice too tight. A crack in the surface.

There was nothing.

The absence pressed harder than the tension ever had.

In class, every seat was filled. Papers passed forward. The teacher smiled and made a joke about caffeine dependency that landed well enough to justify repeating it next period. Someone rolled their eyes in the exact way they always did.

The room felt settled. Cooperative. Intact.

Whatever she had smoothed over had stayed smooth.

Allison's stomach tightened.

At lunch, she sat where she always sat. The table was full. Conversations overlapped in the usual messy way — half-finished stories, complaints about homework, speculation that fizzled out before it could take shape. Someone mentioned a rumor, then shrugged when no one reacted. Another person changed the subject without comment.

It wasn't avoidance.

It was disinterest.

The day moved forward without resistance, and Allison felt herself falling slightly out of step with it. Like she'd learned a rhythm no one else could hear.

She excused herself early and went to the bathroom, locking herself into a stall she'd used a hundred times before. The tile was cold through her jeans. The fluorescent lights buzzed faintly overhead, steady and indifferent.

She waited.

For guilt.

For panic.

For something that would announce itself as consequence.

Nothing came.

Her hands were steady when she washed them.

Her reflection looked the same — pale, tired, ordinary. No visible mark. No signal that anything inside her had changed.

That scared her more than anything else.

By the final bell, the day had passed cleanly. Too clean.

Instead of heading straight home, Allison turned toward the library.

She didn't decide to do it so much as find herself doing it — her feet carrying her down the familiar side street, past the row of houses with matching mailboxes, toward the low brick building tucked behind a line of aging maples.

The library smelled the way it always had: dust, paper, something faintly sweet from the cleaning solution they used on the tables. The door chimed softly when she stepped inside.

It was quiet, but not empty.

An older man sat near the windows reading a newspaper folded into careful thirds. A woman at

the front desk typed slowly, stopping now and then to squint at the screen. Somewhere deeper in the stacks, a cart rattled once and went still.

Allison moved between the shelves without a plan.

She ran her fingers along the spines, reading titles without absorbing them. Local history.

Gardening. Travel guides from years ago. A display near the entrance advertised an upcoming book club meeting. The flyer was printed neatly, cheerful clip art at the corners.

Life continuing. Scheduled.

In the back corner, she found the section she'd spent hours in as a kid — fantasy novels with worn covers and softened edges. Books that promised danger and resolution, conflict that mattered, endings that arrived loudly enough to be acknowledged.

She pulled one halfway off the shelf, then pushed it back.

None of them felt right.

At the checkout desk, a stack of returned books waited to be reshelfed. Allison recognized one — a thin paperback she'd seen the girl from yesterday carrying more than once. The spine was creased. A sticky note peeked out from the top like a placeholder.

The book was back already.

That meant something, she realized dimly. Not about the girl — about the system around her.

Things returned. Items processed. Stories closed and put away.

The librarian smiled at Allison as she passed.

“Find everything okay?”

Allison nodded.

It wasn't a lie.

Outside, the air felt the same as it had an hour ago. The street held. The town didn't push back. At dinner, her mother talked about a problem at work. Her father commented on the weather. Allison listened, nodded, passed the salt when asked. Her voice fit into the conversation without effort.

That frightened her too.

Later, in her room, she lay on her bed with the lights off, phone beside her. She didn't pick it up right away. She didn't need to. The words were already there, waiting.

When she finally opened the Notes app, the screen glowed softly in the dark.

She didn't start with a sentence.

She started with space.

Then she typed.

| Nothing changed today.

She stared at the words until they blurred.

She added another line.

| No one noticed.

Her thumb hovered, waiting for the lie to present itself. Waiting for some internal objection to rise up and correct her.

It didn't.

She locked the phone and turned onto her side, pressing her face into the pillow until the fabric muffled her breathing. The cotton smelled faintly of detergent and sleep.

The house settled around her. Pipes ticked. A car passed outside. Somewhere, a dog barked once and then stopped.

Allison understood then what the real cost was.

Not what she had taken.

What she had made possible.

A world that could absorb harm so quietly it
never had to acknowledge it. A world that
rewarded smoothing over sharp edges until
nothing demanded attention anymore.

A world that would ask again.

She lay awake long after the house went dark,
listening to the steady absence of consequence,
and knowing — with a clarity that left no room
for comfort — that silence was no longer
something she could step away from.

It was something she carried.

And it was not finished with her yet.

* * *

Chapter 18 — The Pattern That Looks Like Help

On Tuesday, the announcements came back. They'd been shorter for a while — fewer reminders, fewer cheerful voices pushing spirit week like it mattered. For days after the incident, the morning intercom had sounded careful, like the school was afraid of saying the wrong thing and waking something up.

Now the voice was bright again.

“Good morning, Alder Creek High! Don't forget—yearbook orders are due Friday!”

A ripple of laughter moved through homeroom at something the announcer said about “the chaos of procrastination.” The teacher at the front of the room smiled, relieved. As if the return of stupid, harmless normal things meant the dangerous things had been handled.

Allison sat still and listened to the easy way the room accepted it.

No one flinched.

No one looked around to see who was missing.

The day proceeded like a machine that had found its groove again.

It wasn't just that it felt normal. It was that the normal had become smoother. Cleaner. Like the school had been sanded down at the edges.

In second period, the teacher asked a question and four hands went up immediately. The shy kid in the back answered without stumbling. The girl who usually stared at her desk made eye contact for a full second before looking away. A boy who had been restless for weeks sat through the lesson without tapping his foot.

It was subtle enough that no one would comment on it.

But Allison saw it.

She could feel it the way you could feel a room after someone stopped crying — the air rearranged, a kind of gentleness settling over the surfaces.

Relief.

Not earned. Not processed. Just... there.

It followed her into the hallway. It followed her into the cafeteria. It followed her into the quiet moment between classes when she stood at her locker and listened to the tide of voices wash past. Everything was a little easier today.

That was what made her stomach turn.

At lunch, someone slid into the seat across from Allison without asking.

Evan.

He didn't sit like he owned the spot. He didn't sit like he was trying to be casual, either. He sat like someone who had rehearsed not looking nervous and failed at it. His backpack stayed on his shoulder, like he might stand up and leave at any second.

Allison stared at him for a beat too long.

He met her eyes and didn't look away.

That was the first thing that felt genuinely different all day.

"Hey," he said.

His voice was low, like he didn't want it to carry.

Like he didn't want the table to overhear itself.

Allison didn't answer right away. Her fork hovered above her food.

"You don't have to—" Evan started, then stopped. He swallowed, his throat working. "I just wanted to check in."

Check in.

The words landed wrong, too neat. Like something you said when there was nothing real you could do.

Allison's grip tightened on the fork.

"Why?" she asked.

It came out flatter than she intended.

Evan's mouth twitched, a small, uncertain motion that might have been the beginning of a smile in another world.

"Because," he said, and then paused again, like the rest of the sentence was heavier than it looked. "Because you've been... alone."

Allison felt something cold move through her chest.

"People keep saying that," she said.

Evan blinked. "They do?"

"No," Allison said, and realized immediately it wasn't true. Her voice sharpened anyway. "They keep acting like I'm not there."

Evan's eyes flicked down to the table, then back up. "Yeah," he said quietly. "That."

The word hung between them, too small for what it meant.

Allison glanced around the cafeteria. The table's conversation kept going without them. Someone laughed at a video. Someone else complained about a teacher. A group two tables over argued about which fast food place was the worst.

No one noticed that Allison had stopped participating.

No one noticed Evan had started.

Allison looked back at him. "You don't even talk to me," she said. "We don't... whatever this is. We don't."

Evan nodded once, like he'd already conceded that point internally.

"I know," he said. "That's kind of why I'm here."
Allison waited.

Evan leaned forward slightly. Not enough to be obvious. Enough to keep their words inside a smaller space.

"I've been noticing things," he said.

Allison's heart stuttered. Her fingers went numb for a second.

"Like what," she asked, and hated how careful she sounded.

Evan's gaze stayed steady, but his hands moved—one thumb rubbing over the edge of his napkin, again and again, like he needed the repetition to hold himself in place.

"Like... people," he said. "The way they change. The way the temperature of a room changes. Like something gets... resolved."

Resolved.

Allison's stomach tightened hard enough to make her nauseous.

"You're imagining it," she said automatically.

It was the kind of sentence she used to write in her Notes. The kind of sentence that used to keep her safe.

Evan didn't smile. He didn't soften.

He just shook his head once.

"No," he said. "I don't think I am."

Allison stared at him.

Evan lowered his voice further. "I'm not saying I understand it," he added quickly. "I'm not saying it's... anything. I just—" He hesitated, and for a moment his expression slipped, something raw and young showing through. "I don't think you're crazy."

The words hit Allison like a shove.

Not because they were kind.

Because they were specific.

Because they were the exact place she'd been hiding.

Allison looked away, her gaze catching on the cafeteria's bright lights, on the glossy floor, on the way the world kept moving like nothing fragile existed inside it.

"I didn't ask you to," she said.

"I know," Evan replied.

His voice was quiet, but it didn't retreat. "I'm asking you."

Allison's throat went tight.

"What are you asking?" she managed.

Evan swallowed. His thumb stopped rubbing the napkin. He held still, like he was bracing.

"I'm asking if it's happening near you," he said.

Allison's breath caught.

Evan continued, careful. "And if it is," he said,

"I'm asking if you're okay."

There it was.

The question people pretended to ask when they didn't want the answer. The question that usually came with an escape route.

Evan didn't offer an escape route.

Allison felt herself leaning toward denial. The familiar reflex. The old language.

I'm fine.

It's nothing.

That happens.

Her mouth opened.

Nothing came out.

Evan watched her, and in his face she saw something that didn't belong to the school's new smoothness.

Concern that didn't resolve itself.

Discomfort that didn't get escorted away.

He wasn't trying to fix her. He wasn't trying to make the room feel better.

He was just... staying.

Allison's hands trembled. She curled them into her lap, out of sight.

"People are calmer," she said finally.

Evan's shoulders shifted, a small movement like relief trying to happen and being held back.

"All the time?" he asked.

Allison stared at the table's scratched surface.

"Today," she said.

Evan nodded slowly, like he was cataloging it, like he was trying not to make the fact of it heavier by reacting wrong.

"Allison," he said.

She looked up at him.

His eyes were intent, careful, frightened in a way he didn't know how to hide. "If that's happening," he said, "it doesn't just... happen. Things don't just change because the air feels like it."

Allison's stomach dropped.

He wasn't accusing her.

But he was too close.

Allison's voice came out sharper than she intended. "What do you want me to say?"

Evan flinched. Just a little. Then he steadied.

"I don't know," he admitted. "I don't. I just—"

He exhaled, slow. "I didn't want to be another person who pretends not to see you."

That landed harder than anything else he'd said.

Because it wasn't about what she'd done.

It was about what everyone else was doing.

Allison looked around the cafeteria again. The laughter, the chatter, the gentle drift of normalcy. A place that could absorb anything, as long as it stayed quiet.

She looked back at Evan.

He was still there.

Still waiting.

Still uncomfortable.

It made her want to cry. It made her want to run.

Instead, she spoke in the only way that felt true.

"I don't know what to do with it," she said.

Evan's face softened—not into reassurance, not into a solution. Just into understanding.

"Okay," he said quietly. "Then... you don't have to do anything with it right now."

Allison stared at him.

"That's not how it works," she said.

Evan's brows drew together. "What do you mean?"

Allison looked away again, and her throat tightened until it hurt.

She didn't answer.

Because if she answered, she would have to admit something that had been forming inside her since yesterday.

That it did work like that now.

That the world didn't wait for her consent.

That it would keep leaning toward endings, and she would keep feeling the pressure to resolve them.

Evan shifted, his voice softer. "I'm not going to tell anyone," he said.

Allison almost laughed.

Not because it was funny.

Because the promise was too small for the thing sitting between them.

“It’s not about telling,” she whispered.
Evan’s eyes widened slightly, like he felt the edge of what she meant and didn’t know how to step closer without falling.
Allison swallowed. Her chest hurt.
The cafeteria noise swelled around them, warm and oblivious.
Somewhere near the doors, someone called Evan’s name.
Evan glanced that way once, then back at Allison.
“I have to go,” he said. “But—”
He stopped.
Then, in a motion so quick it almost looked like a mistake, he slid something across the table toward her.
A folded piece of paper.
Allison stared at it.
Evan stood, backpack shifting on his shoulder.
“It’s just... my number,” he said, voice tight. “In case. If you ever—”
He didn’t finish the sentence.
He didn’t have to.
Allison didn’t touch the paper right away.
Evan hesitated one last time, like he wanted to say more, like he wanted to make the moment safer.
Then he turned and disappeared into the current of the cafeteria, swallowed by noise and routine.
Allison sat alone at the table that wasn’t really hers.
The folded paper lay in front of her.
Nothing about it looked dangerous.
But her hands wouldn’t stop trembling.
When she finally picked it up, the paper was warm from Evan’s fingers, and the warmth felt wrong in her palm — too human, too present, too

much like an invitation.

She tucked it into her pocket anyway.

After school, she walked home slowly.

The town held its shape around her. The sky was pale. The air smelled faintly of damp leaves.

Somewhere, a lawnmower started up, then stopped.

Everything normal.

Everything quiet.

In her room that night, she picked up her phone and stared at the dark screen for a long moment before unlocking it.

She opened her Notes app.

Notes:

| He saw it.

| He stayed.

She locked the phone before her hands could change their mind.

* * *

Chapter 19 — The Cost of Being Seen

The first thing Allison noticed was that it didn't feel urgent.

That, more than anything, told her she was already too late.

She woke with the sense that something had shifted slightly out of alignment — not wrong, not broken, just angled enough that it would keep catching her attention all day. Her phone sat where she'd left it on the nightstand. Evan's folded number was still in her pocket from yesterday, creased now, softened by warmth and movement.

Nothing had happened overnight.

That was the problem.

At breakfast, her parents talked over each other in the familiar way that meant neither of them was actually listening. Her mother asked if she'd finished her math homework. Her father commented on the weather like it was a personal achievement.

Allison answered when spoken to. She smiled when appropriate. She moved through the morning like she was supposed to.

But there was a new pressure behind her eyes, a low awareness that didn't belong to the day itself. A sense of being slightly misaligned with the flow of things, like she was standing just a fraction of a second out of step.

Someone else knew.

Not everything. Not the shape of it. But enough.

At school, she felt it before she saw him.

Evan wasn't waiting for her. He didn't hover. He didn't seek her out.

He just existed in the same spaces she did.
In the hallway between first and second period,
Allison spotted him talking to someone near the
lockers. He laughed at something they said, the
sound quick and unforced. When his gaze flicked
up and found her, he didn't freeze.
He nodded.
Not a greeting.
Not a signal.
An acknowledgment.
Allison's stomach tightened.
The rest of the hallway flowed around them like
nothing had changed. No one slowed. No one
noticed the small line of attention that had formed
and then dissolved again.
Evan went back to his conversation.
Allison kept walking.
She told herself that was fine.
She told herself a lot of things like that now.
It wasn't until third period that she understood
what had actually changed.
The class discussion drifted, as it often did,
toward something personal — a hypothetical that
wasn't really hypothetical, framed just vaguely
enough to invite opinions without demanding
vulnerability. Normally, Allison would stay quiet
through that kind of thing. She'd learned early
that silence was safer.
Today, the teacher paused and looked directly at
her.
"Allison," she said, pleasantly. "What do you
think?"
The question landed softly.
The room waited.
Allison felt the familiar urge to smooth things
over, to give an answer that would keep the

discussion moving without disturbing anyone.
The words lined up easily in her mouth, already
shaped to fit the space.

She hesitated.

Just long enough to feel the weight of the
attention settle fully on her shoulders.

Evan sat two rows over. She didn't look at him,
but she could feel his presence anyway — not
watching, exactly. Just aware.

She answered. Short. Neutral. Acceptable.

The teacher nodded, satisfied, and turned to
someone else.

The class moved on.

But the attention didn't leave all at once. It
thinned, stretched, lingered in places it hadn't
before.

After class, a girl Allison barely spoke to caught
up with her at the door. "That was a good point,"
she said, smiling like this was a normal exchange
between them.

Allison nodded back, unsure what expression to
wear.

It wasn't friendliness that unsettled her.

It was access.

By lunchtime, she understood the shape of it
more clearly.

Being seen didn't mean being exposed.

It meant being included.

People looked at her a little longer. Teachers
called on her without hesitation. Classmates
folded her into conversations she hadn't asked to
join, like she'd always belonged there and they
were only just realizing it.

No one asked her to explain anything.

No one demanded answers.

They just... assumed.

At her locker, Evan appeared beside her without warning. Not close. Just close enough to share space without claiming it.

“Hey,” he said.

Allison closed her locker carefully, the click loud in her ears. “You don’t have to do that,” she said.

“Do what?”

“Check on me,” she replied. “I’m fine.”

The words came out automatically. She hated that they still did, that they slid into place like a reflex she hadn’t unlearned.

Evan watched her for a moment, expression unreadable. Then he nodded.

“Okay,” he said.

And stepped back.

The relief she felt was immediate — sharp, almost dizzying.

It was followed just as quickly by something worse.

Disappointment.

She turned away before she could examine it, before it could turn into something she didn’t know how to carry.

The pressure followed her through the afternoon, subtle but persistent. It wasn’t pulling her toward action. It wasn’t asking her to fix anything.

It was asking her to be present.

After school, she cut through the side streets instead of taking the main road. The houses looked the same as they always had. Sprinklers clicked on and off. Someone’s radio played faintly through an open window, the music too soft to make out the words.

Normal.

Too normal.

At home, her phone buzzed while she was doing homework.

A new number.

She stared at the screen longer than she needed to. For a moment, she considered not opening it. Not because she was afraid of what it would say — but because opening it would make the connection real in a way that couldn't be undone. Finally, she unlocked the phone.

Evan:

You don't have to respond. I just wanted you to know I meant what I said.

Allison's chest tightened.

She set the phone face-down on the desk.

Minutes passed. Then more.

The room didn't demand anything from her. The quiet pressed in, patient, waiting.

She picked the phone back up.

Her fingers hovered over the screen.

She typed one word.

Okay.

She stared at it.

Then erased it.

She tried again.

Thanks.

That didn't feel right either.

The problem wasn't the words.

It was what answering would mean.

When her phone buzzed again, she flinched.

Evan:

I'm not trying to fix anything.

Allison let out a breath she hadn't realized she was holding. The relief was small, but it mattered. That night, lying in bed with the lights off, she felt the familiar hum under her skin — the sense of the world leaning toward resolution, toward

smoothness, toward the quiet ending of things
that pressed too hard.

But now there was something else layered over it.
Attention.

Expectation.

Not the sharp, demanding kind she'd learned to
handle — but the soft kind that lingered. The kind
that waited.

Being seen hadn't taken her ability away.

But it had changed its cost.

Because now, when she chose silence, it wasn't
empty.

It was watched.

And she understood, with a clarity that made her
stomach ache, that the world wouldn't just ask
her to fix things anymore.

It would ask her to stay.

And staying, she suspected, might be harder than
ending anything at all.

* * *

Chapter 20 — When Nothing Is Wrong

The counselor's office smelled like lemon cleaner and old paper.

Allison noticed that first, because noticing small things was easier than thinking about why she was there.

She sat in the chair across from the desk, hands folded in her lap, posture careful. The walls were covered in posters about stress management and college readiness. A chart about sleep habits hung crookedly near the door. A bowl of wrapped candies sat within easy reach, untouched. The clock above the filing cabinet ticked softly, loud enough that she found herself counting the seconds between movements.

Ms. Harlan smiled at her in a way that was meant to be reassuring.

"Thank you for coming in," she said. "This won't take long."

Allison nodded.

That phrase — won't take long — was usually reserved for things that were already decided.

Ms. Harlan glanced down at the folder on her desk. Not thick. Not thin. Just present. She didn't open it. She didn't need to.

"We've been doing routine check-ins," she said.

"Nothing formal. Just making sure students are... supported."

Supported.

Allison waited.

"There's no issue," Ms. Harlan continued quickly, as if anticipating resistance. "Your grades are steady. Attendance is good. Teachers have mentioned you seem engaged. Calmer."

The word landed softly, like a compliment. Like a relief someone else got to feel.

Allison's throat tightened. "Okay."

Ms. Harlan smiled again, this time more openly.

"I'm glad to hear that."

She reached for the candy bowl and nudged it slightly closer, then seemed to realize what she was doing and laughed softly. "Sorry. Habit."

Allison didn't reach for it.

Ms. Harlan leaned back in her chair.

"Sometimes," she said, "when things settle after a difficult period, it can feel strange. Like you're waiting for something to happen."

Allison kept her expression neutral. She focused on the edge of the desk, the small chip in the veneer near the corner. She wondered how long it had been there. Whether anyone else ever noticed it.

"But nothing has to happen," Ms. Harlan added gently. "It's okay to let things be good."

Good.

The word hovered between them, full and finished, like it closed something Allison hadn't agreed to open.

Allison nodded again. It felt easier than speaking. Easier than saying something that might require clarification.

Ms. Harlan closed the folder without opening it.

"If you ever want to talk," she said, standing now, already halfway toward the end of the meeting, "my door is always open. No pressure."

No pressure.

Allison thanked her and walked back into the hallway.

The bell rang just as she stepped outside the office. Students flowed past, voices rising and

falling in familiar patterns. Someone laughed loudly. Someone else complained about a quiz. A teacher clapped their hands once, calling for attention, then stopped when the noise settled on its own.

The day continued without interruption.

Nothing was wrong.

That was the message.

In English class, the teacher returned essays with a satisfied hum. "Overall, really thoughtful work," she said. "A lot of maturity in here."

Her gaze lingered on Allison for a fraction of a second longer than usual.

Allison lowered her eyes to the paper on her desk.

The grade was good. The comments were encouraging. Nothing asked for more. Nothing invited disagreement.

Later, in the hallway, a guidance aide smiled at her in passing. "You doing okay today?" she asked, already walking.

Allison nodded automatically.

"Good," the woman said, relieved, and disappeared into a classroom.

At lunch, a teacher Allison barely knew stopped by her table. "Everything going okay?" she asked, casual, friendly. "You seem really grounded lately."

Grounded.

Allison nodded. She was getting good at that.

No one lingered long enough for the answer to matter.

After school, she found Evan by the bike racks, adjusting the strap on his backpack. He looked up when she approached, expression open but cautious, like he didn't want to assume anything.

"They pulled me out of class," Allison said.

Evan stilled. "Are you in trouble?"

"No," she said. "They just wanted to check in."

He exhaled slowly, tension easing from his shoulders. "Okay."

"They said everything's fine," Allison added.

"That I'm doing well."

Evan frowned slightly. "And are you?"

Allison hesitated.

This was the difference, she realized. The counselor had been asking so the conversation could end. Evan was asking so it could continue.

"I don't know," she said.

Evan nodded, accepting that answer without trying to improve it. "That's fair."

They stood there for a moment, the air between them unhurried. Around them, students streamed past on their way home. Someone's phone played music too loud. A car honked and then drove on. Normal.

Evan shifted his weight. "You don't have to explain anything," he said. "I just wanted to say... people seem relieved lately. Like everyone's breathing easier."

Allison looked at him.

"Yeah," she said.

Evan hesitated. "I don't think that's because things got better."

Allison felt a small, sharp flare of something in her chest. Not fear. Recognition.

"They think it did," she said.

Evan nodded. "That's what worries me."

They walked part of the way home together, not close enough to be obvious, not far enough to pretend they weren't together. When they reached the corner where Evan turned off, he stopped.

“If you ever need me to be... not fine with things,” he said, choosing his words carefully, “I can do that.”

Allison looked at him, really looked at him.

“Thank you,” she said.

He smiled, brief and crooked, then headed down his street.

Allison continued on alone.

At home, her parents asked about her day. She gave the usual answers. Homework. Lunch.

Nothing special. They nodded, content, already turning their attention elsewhere.

Later, she heard her mother on the phone in the kitchen, voice light. “She’s doing great,” she said.

“Yeah. I think everything’s settled.”

Allison stayed in her room.

That night, she lay in bed staring at the ceiling, listening to the house settle. Pipes ticked. A car passed outside. Somewhere, a TV murmured and went quiet.

She felt the familiar pull toward smoothness, toward letting the day be complete and unremarkable.

But now there was something else layered into it. Expectation.

Not spoken.

Not demanded.

Just waiting.

She picked up her phone and opened her Notes app.

Notes:

| They asked how I was.

| They were relieved when I said “okay.”

She stared at the words.

They felt accurate. Incomplete. Dangerous.

She locked the phone and set it aside.

Nothing was wrong.

And she was beginning to understand how much
that answer could cost.

* * *

Chapter 21 — The Shape of Help

It started with the room.

Allison noticed it in history class, of all places — a subject that usually felt inert, predictable, like it would keep moving no matter who was present. The teacher was midway through a lecture, voice steady, when a disagreement flickered between two students in the back row. Nothing serious. A raised voice. A sharp reply. The kind of moment that usually lingered just long enough to draw attention.

Normally, the tension would have hovered, waiting for correction.

This time, it didn't.

The voices dropped. One of them shrugged, like the energy had drained out of the argument. Someone else cracked a joke that wasn't very funny, but it landed anyway. The moment thinned and disappeared, leaving only the scrape of chairs and the soft hum of the classroom settling back into itself.

The teacher didn't notice. Or if she did, she treated it as already resolved.

Allison sat still, hands flat on the desk, heart beating a little too fast. She hadn't moved. She hadn't thought anything through. She hadn't even been aware of the disagreement until it was already fading.

She waited for the familiar after-feeling — the sense of something closing, of quiet being earned. It didn't come.

The class continued. Notes were taken. The bell rang.

The feeling stayed.

In the hallway, a knot of students clustered near the lockers, blocking the way. Backpacks bumped. Someone sighed sharply. A minor standoff formed, irritation rising in small, uneven pulses.

Allison slowed, instinctively. She considered waiting it out, letting the moment burn itself down.

Before she reached them, the group shifted. Someone stepped aside. Someone else murmured an apology, not directed at her exactly, but offered into the space between bodies. The path opened with minimal fuss, like it had always been meant to.

Allison walked through.

No one looked at her.

Her shoulders didn't relax until she was halfway down the hall.

At lunch, she took a seat at the end of a table already half full. Conversations continued without pause, voices overlapping, trays sliding across the plastic surface. Someone nudged a backpack out of the way to make room. No comment. No acknowledgment.

She unwrapped her sandwich and ate slowly, trying not to draw attention to herself.

Across the table, a boy she didn't know very well was talking too loudly about a test. His frustration edged toward anger, words tightening as he went. Halfway through a sentence, he stopped.

"Never mind," he said, waving a hand. "It's fine." The tension drained from his posture. The people nearest him relaxed without comment. Someone changed the subject.

No one asked what he'd been about to say.

The table softened.

Allison stared at her food, appetite fading.
It wasn't that people were calmer because of her.
That framing felt wrong — too direct, too deliberate.

It was that calm arrived more easily when she was present.

Like the space around her gave things permission to settle.

The distinction mattered.

After school, she went to the library, more out of habit than intention. The building was dim and cool, the air heavy with the smell of paper and dust. The quiet there was different — layered, patient. A librarian moved between the stacks, reshelving returns with careful movements.

Allison took a seat at one of the long tables and pulled out her homework. She hadn't been there five minutes when a woman approached, arms full of books.

"Excuse me," she said, already smiling. "Do you mind if I sit here?"

There were plenty of empty seats.

"No," Allison said, shifting slightly to make room.

The woman set her books down with a soft thud and let out a long breath, shoulders dropping.

"Thank you," she said. "It's been one of those days."

Allison nodded.

The woman didn't elaborate. She didn't need to. She opened her book and settled in, the tension in her posture easing as if she'd reached a safe place.

The quiet deepened.

Allison stared at the page in front of her, the words blurring. She felt suddenly crowded, even

though no one was touching her.

She closed her notebook, packed up her things,
and left before the woman looked up again.

On the walk home, she took a different route,
cutting through the park. Children played on the
swings, laughter rising and falling in uneven
bursts. A dog barked once, then stopped when its
owner tugged gently on the leash. A man on a
bench rubbed his temples, then leaned back and
closed his eyes.

Everything felt... eased.

Not fixed.

Not healed.

Just easier.

As if effort had been quietly removed from the
world.

At home, her mother was on the phone in the
kitchen, voice tight with something Allison
recognized as worry. Allison paused in the
doorway, not meaning to listen.

"I don't know what to tell you," her mother said.

"It just worked itself out."

A short laugh followed, thin but relieved. "Yeah.
It's fine now."

Allison backed away and went to her room.

She sat on the edge of the bed, shoes still on,
staring at the carpet. She tried to catalog what had
happened, to put edges around it.

She hadn't intervened.

She hadn't chosen anything.

She hadn't written anything down.

And yet.

She picked up her phone and opened her Notes
app.

Notes:

| I didn't do anything.

| Things still got quieter.
She stared at the words until they blurred.
This was worse.
Because if her presence alone was enough — if
simply being there changed the shape of things —
then there was no clean way to refuse. No
obvious moment to step back. No clear line where
responsibility began.
Silence was no longer something she did.
It was something that gathered around her.
She locked the phone and set it aside.
Outside her window, the neighborhood settled
into evening. Lights flicked on one by one. Doors
closed. Conversations drifted and then faded.
The world continued.
And Allison felt it, pressing gently against her
from all sides — not asking, not insisting.
Just making room.
For her.
And expecting her to stay.

* * *

Chapter 22 — The Moment That Doesn't Pass

Allison noticed the shift too late to prevent it. It was small. Ordinary. The kind of thing that happened every day and never made it into anyone's memory as more than a mild irritation. It started in fourth period.

The teacher paired them off for a short in-class assignment. Allison ended up with a girl she'd spoken to maybe twice all semester — Mariah, quiet and precise, always color-coding her notes. They sat together without discomfort, flipping through a packet, reading the questions in silence that felt practiced rather than awkward.

It should have been easy.

Halfway through, Mariah's pencil snapped.

The sound was sharp in the quiet classroom, louder than it had any right to be.

Mariah froze. She stared at the broken pencil like it had betrayed her personally. For a second, Allison saw something flicker across her face — anger, embarrassment, exhaustion. Something that didn't belong in the neat margins of her notebook or the careful slant of her handwriting. Mariah's breathing hitched once.

Allison felt it immediately: the familiar tightening in the room. The small, collective pause that came before someone stepped in. The shape of a moment that wanted to be smoothed over.

Normally, Allison would have reached for quiet without thinking. A word. A gesture. Something light enough to redirect the moment before it could grow edges.

She could have offered her pencil.

She could have made a joke.
She could have said it's fine in the right tone and ended it.
She didn't.
Not because she was trying to prove anything.
Because she was tired.
Because she wanted — just once — to see what happened if she didn't make the edges soft.
Mariah's eyes flicked toward her.
Waiting.
Allison kept her hands on the desk.
The moment stretched.
Mariah swallowed. Her shoulders drew in slightly, like she was bracing herself. She reached into her backpack with quick, jerky movements, pulling out another pencil. It slipped from her fingers and clattered to the floor.
The sound echoed more than it should have.
A couple of students glanced over. The teacher paused mid-sentence, eyes lifting briefly, then continued when Mariah didn't speak.
Mariah's face flushed, color rising too fast.
She bent down sharply, hair falling forward, hands fumbling as she grabbed the pencil. When she sat back up, her eyes were glassy, fixed firmly on the paper in front of her.
Allison's chest tightened.
The discomfort in the room didn't drain away.
It stayed.
Mariah cleared her throat. "Sorry," she muttered, voice barely audible.
Allison forced herself to speak, though her voice felt thin, too late. "It's okay."
Mariah nodded too fast, relief flickering across her face — not because the moment had passed, but because Allison had finally acknowledged it.

She turned back to the worksheet. Her handwriting, usually perfect, wavered slightly as she filled in the answers.

The rest of the period passed, but the air never fully reset. The room felt altered — not tense, not loud. Just unsettled, like a small crack had been left unsealed.

Allison carried that feeling with her when the bell rang.

She expected it to fade in the hallway.

It didn't.

Students flowed around her, talking, laughing, bumping shoulders. Everything looked normal, but the sense of unfinishedness lingered, like a low hum she couldn't tune out.

At lunch, the table was already half full when she arrived. People shifted automatically to make space, the way they had been doing lately — smooth, practiced, unquestioned.

Allison sat.

Conversation continued.

But there was a thinness to it. A carefulness. Like everyone was staying close to safe topics on purpose.

Someone complained about homework. Someone else laughed too loudly. A joke landed and died almost immediately.

Allison listened, waiting for the moment when the table would relax again.

It didn't.

Across from her, Jenna — who always filled silences without noticing — kept glancing at Allison and then away. Finally, she leaned forward, lowering her voice.

“Are you... okay?” Jenna asked.

Allison's stomach tightened. “Yeah.”

Jenna nodded, not fully convinced. “You’ve just been... quiet.”

The word landed strangely.

Quiet had always been Allison’s default. It had never required explanation before.

“I’m fine,” Allison said again.

Jenna smiled, relieved — but the relief didn’t spread. It hovered, uncertain, like it was waiting for something more definitive.

Someone changed the subject. The conversation limped forward.

Allison ate without tasting much of anything.

After school, she walked home slower than usual, taking a longer route without quite deciding to.

The town looked the same — houses, trees, sidewalks. A dog barked behind a fence and then went silent. Sprinklers ticked on and off in uneven rhythm.

Nothing was wrong.

And yet the day felt slightly off, like it had skipped a step and kept going anyway.

At home, her mother asked how school was.

Allison said, “Fine,” and her mother accepted it too quickly, relief softening her shoulders as she turned back to whatever she’d been doing.

That night, Allison sat on her bed with her phone in her hands, the screen dark.

When she opened her Notes app, the blank page waited.

She didn’t type right away.

She replayed Mariah’s face — the flash of emotion, the waiting look, the way the moment had stretched when Allison hadn’t reached in to end it.

She had wanted to see what would happen.

Now she knew.

Nothing terrible.

Nothing dramatic.

Just discomfort that stayed where it was.

And the quiet, unmistakable awareness that people noticed when it stayed.

Allison typed.

Notes:

| I didn't fix it.

| It didn't go away.

She stared at the words.

They didn't accuse her.

They didn't excuse her either.

They felt like a warning — not about what she had done, but about what she had allowed to remain.

She locked the phone and lay back on her bed, staring at the ceiling.

The house was quiet.

The street outside was quiet.

But inside her, the unpassed moment sat heavy.

And she understood that refusing didn't look like rebellion.

It looked like letting the world stay uncomfortable long enough for someone to notice.

And that, she suspected, might be enough to change everything.

* * *

Chapter 23 — What It Costs to Stay

Allison knew, before the day even started, that she was going to have to choose.

Not between right and wrong.

Not between helping and hurting.

Between staying and smoothing.

The knowledge sat with her through breakfast, through the walk to school, through the quiet routines that had begun to feel weighted with expectation. Nothing unusual happened. No sharp moments presented themselves. No obvious edges appeared.

That didn't ease the tension.

In chemistry, the lab groups were uneven. Two students argued quietly over measurements, irritation building in clipped exchanges that never quite rose to confrontation. Allison heard it from her station across the room, the way she'd begun to hear these things now — not loudly, but clearly.

She felt the familiar pull.

Not a command.

Not an urge.

A possibility.

If she shifted her attention.

If she leaned in just enough.

The moment would thin. The disagreement would soften into something manageable. Relief would follow, light and immediate.

She didn't move.

The argument didn't escalate. It didn't resolve either.

It stayed awkward, unresolved — the kind of low friction that made everyone nearby slightly

uncomfortable without giving them anything specific to react to. The teacher glanced over once, frowned, then turned back to another group. Allison kept her eyes on her notes, hands steady. The class ended with the air still faintly unsettled. She carried that feeling with her into the hallway, bracing for it to follow her the way it had before — to gather, to lean, to wait.

It didn't.

The hallway buzzed with its usual noise. Lockers slammed. Someone shouted a name down the corridor. A laugh rose and cut off abruptly. Life continued, imperfect and noisy.

The relief was small, but it was real.

At lunch, she sat with the same group as always. The table filled around her, trays clattering into place. Conversation wandered — homework complaints, weekend plans, a teacher someone didn't like.

Allison listened, waiting.

Nothing pressed.

For a moment, she wondered if she'd imagined the weight she'd been carrying. If maybe the shape of things had shifted back on its own, correcting quietly without her involvement.

Then a girl at the end of the table — one of the quieter ones, easy to overlook — spoke up.

"I don't think it's fair," she said. Her voice was tentative but steady. "That we have to redo the whole project because one group messed up."

The table stilled.

It was a small complaint. A reasonable one. The kind of comment that usually got smoothed over quickly — either by agreement or by someone reframing it until it felt less sharp, less worth holding onto.

Allison felt the pull immediately.
She knew how this went. A few words, delivered calmly. A reminder that it wasn't that bad. That it wasn't personal. Relief would follow. The table would loosen. The moment would disappear. She didn't speak.
The silence stretched longer than it needed to. A couple of people shifted in their seats. Someone cleared their throat.
Jenna glanced at Allison, then back at the girl. "I mean," she said slowly, "it's not ideal, but that's just how group work goes."
The girl's shoulders tightened. "I know. I just—" She stopped, lips pressing together, the rest of the sentence left unsaid.
The discomfort lingered.
Allison felt it clearly now — the way the moment waited, not for resolution, but for her. Not because anyone had asked. Not because anyone had named it.
Just because she was there.
She stayed still.
Finally, someone else changed the subject, abruptly and clumsily. The conversation lurched forward, uneven but moving.
The girl stared down at her tray.
Allison's chest tightened.
This was the cost she hadn't wanted to name. Staying meant watching someone else carry the weight she could have lifted. It meant letting the discomfort land where it fell instead of absorbing it herself.
The rest of lunch passed without incident, but the table never fully relaxed again. The moment left a residue — not obvious, not dramatic, just present.

After school, Allison found Evan by the bike racks. He looked up when he saw her, searching her face the way he always did now — not for answers, just for truth.

“You look tired,” he said.

“I am,” Allison replied.

They walked together for a few blocks, the afternoon warm and muted. Cars passed occasionally, tires hissing against the pavement.

A breeze stirred dry leaves along the curb.

Evan spoke first. “Did something happen?”

Allison considered deflecting. It would have been easy.

“I didn’t fix something,” she said instead.

Evan nodded, unsurprised. “How’d that go?”

She hesitated. “It stayed uncomfortable.”

He glanced at her. “And?”

“And people noticed.”

Evan didn’t smile. He didn’t try to soften it. He just absorbed the information.

“Do you regret it?” he asked.

Allison thought about the girl at the table. About the way her shoulders had tightened. About the small relief she’d felt earlier when the hallway hadn’t pressed in on her.

“Yes,” she said. “And no.”

Evan nodded. “That sounds about right.”

They reached the corner where Evan turned off. He stopped, shifting his backpack higher on his shoulder.

“For what it’s worth,” he said, “staying isn’t the same thing as doing nothing.”

Allison looked at him.

“I know,” she said. “That’s the problem.”

He smiled faintly — something sad and steady in it. “I’m still here.”

“I know,” she said again.

At home, Allison went to her room and closed the door. She sat on the bed, phone in her hand, the familiar weight of it grounding her.

She opened her Notes app.

Notes:

| I stayed.

| It cost someone else.

She stared at the words.

They were heavier than any she’d written before.

Not because they accused her.

Because they were true.

She locked the phone and set it aside.

Outside, the evening settled in. The house hummed with ordinary sounds. No consequences arrived. No resolution followed.

But Allison felt the narrowing clearly now — the path ahead thinning as choices accumulated.

Staying didn’t make things better.

It made them real.

And she understood, with a clarity that didn’t bring comfort, that this was the future she was choosing.

One where ease would no longer arrive quietly.

And where she would have to live with what didn’t.

* * *

Chapter 24 — What Doesn't Settle

The day it became obvious was not dramatic. No one confronted Allison. No one cornered her in a hallway or demanded answers she couldn't give. There were no raised voices, no calls home, no meetings with a principal whose face she would remember later.

It happened the way most things happened now. Quietly.

In pieces.

It started with a teacher.

Ms. Donnelly — the one who taught English with a tired patience that made her feel older than she probably was — stopped Allison after class. The other students filed out, chairs scraping, conversations already shifting away from the room. Allison gathered her papers slowly, hoping the pause was accidental.

"Hey," Ms. Donnelly said, gentle. "Can I talk to you for a second?"

Allison's stomach tightened. "Sure."

Ms. Donnelly didn't look stern. She looked careful. Like she was choosing words that wouldn't start something she couldn't finish.

"I just wanted to check in," she said. "You've seemed... steady lately."

Allison nodded.

"And," Ms. Donnelly continued, "you're the kind of student people trust. You know that?"

The words were meant as a compliment.

They didn't land like one.

Allison's fingers tightened around her folder.

"Okay."

Ms. Donnelly smiled slightly, relief flickering across her face. "There's been some... tension in class. Not anything serious. Just normal stuff." Normal stuff.

Allison waited.

"I've noticed that when you're engaged," Ms. Donnelly said, lowering her voice, "the room feels calmer. Other students follow you. They take cues from you."

Something cold moved through Allison's chest. This wasn't accusation.

It wasn't even request.

It was expectation, carefully padded.

"I'm not asking you to do anything you're not comfortable with," Ms. Donnelly added quickly.

"I just... if you ever feel like speaking up when things get a little messy, it helps. You have a grounding presence."

Grounding.

The word felt too solid for something so fragile.

"I don't know," Allison said, choosing the safest truth she had.

Ms. Donnelly nodded, understanding too quickly.

"Of course. And you shouldn't feel responsible. I just wanted you to know you're doing well. That people respond to you."

Respond.

Ms. Donnelly smiled again — warm, approving — and stepped aside, the conversation already over in her mind.

Allison walked into the hallway with her skin feeling too tight.

No one had named the thing she could do.

No one had asked her to use it.

But the shape of it was there now, held gently and handed back to her as something she was already

carrying.

On the way to lunch, Allison cut through the courtyard. The sky was pale, the air cool enough to sting her lungs. A cluster of students sat on the low wall near the entrance, voices low.

One of them was crying quietly.

A friend leaned close, whispering. Another rested a hand on her shoulder, uncertain.

Allison slowed.

The crying girl looked up as Allison passed.

Their eyes met.

The girl's expression shifted — not hope, not pleading. Something smaller. Something like recognition. Like a question she hadn't been allowed to ask out loud.

Allison kept walking.

The girl's eyes followed her until she was gone.

At lunch, Allison didn't go to her usual table right away. She drifted with her tray, scanning for an empty spot.

The cafeteria felt dense. Not chaotic. Just layered with too many voices, too many half-held emotions.

She sat alone at the end of a long table.

Within minutes, someone slid into the seat across from her.

Not Evan.

A boy from her math class — Tyler. Someone she recognized but didn't know.

"Hey," he said, awkward. "Is it okay if I sit here?"

There were plenty of empty tables.

"Sure," Allison said.

Tyler didn't eat. He picked at the edge of his wrapper, eyes fixed on the table between them.

"I just wanted to say," he began, then stopped.

Allison waited.

“You’re... good at keeping things calm,” he said finally. “Like, you don’t freak out.”

The words landed heavier than he seemed to expect.

“Okay,” Allison said.

He laughed nervously. “Sorry. That sounds weird.”

“It’s fine,” Allison said automatically — and hated how quickly it came out.

Tyler nodded, relieved by the familiar phrase.

“It’s just... my mom’s been a mess lately,” he said, the words spilling now. “And I’m trying to keep everything together and—” He stopped, blinking hard. “Never mind.”

The moment waited.

Not in the air.

Not in the room.

In Tyler’s face. In the stillness of his hands.

Allison felt the pull — the ease with which she could make this softer, shorter, forgettable.

She didn’t.

She took a slow breath. “That sounds hard,” she said.

Tyler blinked, surprised. His eyes went glassy.

Allison didn’t offer reassurance. She didn’t promise anything would be okay.

She stayed.

Tyler nodded once. “Yeah,” he said quietly.

They ate in silence after that — not the kind that erased what had been said, but the kind that made space for it.

Across the cafeteria, Allison saw Jenna glance at her. Saw the curiosity in her expression. Saw a couple of other students look too, then look away when Allison met their eyes.

Her stomach tightened.

This wasn't about what she could do.

It was about who people were beginning to look to.

After school, Evan waited near the edge of the courtyard. He wasn't in her way. He wasn't even looking directly at her at first, like he was giving her space to decide.

Allison walked up anyway.

"Something happened," she said.

Evan nodded, unsurprised. "Yeah?"

"A teacher talked to me," Allison said. "She said people follow me. That I make things calmer."

Evan's jaw tightened. "They're starting to say it out loud."

"Not the real thing," Allison said. "Just the version that makes sense to them."

"The version that turns it into praise," Evan said. Allison nodded. "I don't want it."

"I know," Evan said.

"If I let things stay uncomfortable," Allison said, voice tight, "people look at me like I'm doing something wrong. And if I make things easier, they're relieved like they can finally breathe again."

Evan was quiet for a moment. "That's the trap."

Allison looked at him. "I don't know how to live in the middle."

"You don't have to figure it out all at once," Evan said. "But you shouldn't have to disappear to make it work."

Together meant witnesses.

It meant memory.

It meant that whatever she chose would last.

She nodded anyway.

That night, Allison lay in bed staring at the ceiling, phone warm in her hand.

She opened her Notes app.

The blank page waited.

Notes:

| They don't know what I do.

| They only know how they feel around me.

She paused.

Then added:

| They want me to stay calm.

| They want me to make it easier.

Her thumb hovered.

She didn't write a solution.

She didn't soften the language.

She added the last line carefully.

| I can't keep disappearing for them.

She stared at it until her eyes burned.

Then she locked the phone and set it aside.

Outside, the neighborhood settled into quiet.

Lights dimmed. Doors closed. The world moved toward sleep as if nothing was wrong.

Allison lay still.

Nothing had exploded.

Nothing had been fixed.

But the future had narrowed into something she could no longer pretend was temporary.

What didn't settle wasn't the world.

It was her.

And she was going to stay that way.

* * *

Epilogue — What Is Withheld

Evan had learned, over time, how to speak without saying too much.

It wasn't something his parents had ever sat him down and taught. It came from the way questions were asked at the dinner table. From the pauses that followed answers. From the understanding that some things weren't hidden because they were forbidden, but because they were heavy. They were in the kitchen, the evening routine unfolding the way it always did. His mother stood at the sink, rinsing a mug that didn't really need it. His father leaned against the counter, arms crossed, listening in the way he did when he was pretending not to listen yet.

"So," his father said lightly, "how's school?"

Evan shrugged. "Fine."

His mother smiled without turning around. "That usually means something changed."

Evan considered denying it. He didn't.

"There's a girl," he said. "Someone I've been spending time with."

His father shifted his weight. Not alarmed. Just attentive.

"Oh," his mother said. "Is this a good thing?"

"I think so," Evan said. Then, after a moment, "I'm not sure."

He searched for language that felt honest without being invasive. "She's... steady," he said.

"Things don't fall apart around her the way they do with other people."

The faucet turned off.

His mother dried her hands slowly. "Does she know you've noticed that?"

“No,” Evan said. “She doesn’t think about it the same way.”

His father’s expression sharpened. “Is anything happening around her? Anything she’s asking questions about?”

Evan shook his head. “She’s not asking. She’s not trying to do anything.”

That earned him a longer pause.

“What’s her name?” his mother asked.

Evan felt the moment arrive cleanly. Not sudden.

Not frightening. Just... final.

“I don’t want to say,” he replied.

His parents looked at him.

Not surprised.

Not disappointed.

Reassessing.

His father exhaled slowly. “That’s a decision.”

“Yes,” Evan said. “It is.”

His mother studied his face, searching for uncertainty and not finding it. Finally, she nodded. “All right.”

The moment passed without argument. Without pressure.

His father checked the clock. “You should get started on your homework.”

Evan nodded and headed down the hall, the quiet following him like something that had been deliberately allowed. He closed his bedroom door gently and sat on the edge of his bed, heart steady, aware only that he’d just drawn a line he didn’t know how to erase.

He didn’t hear the way the kitchen changed after he left.

His mother waited until the hallway was still.

Then she spoke.

“That was sooner than I expected.”

His father nodded. "He didn't hesitate."

"No," she said softly. "That's what scares me."

They sat at the table now, the ease gone. Not replaced by panic — by honesty.

"She's untrained," his father said. "No sign of guidance. No attempt at control."

"And yet the effect is consistent," his mother replied. "It settles things."

He frowned. "Unintentional manifestation."

She nodded once. "The rare kind."

"And the most dangerous," he said quietly. "Not because of what she can do. Because she doesn't know she's doing it."

His mother's hand tightened around her mug. "Or because she's choosing not to."

That gave him pause.

"She hasn't been registered," he said.

"No," she replied. "And Evan won't give us her name."

His father leaned back, eyes on the ceiling. "That tells me more about him than it does about her."

"It tells me he understands what naming costs," she said.

They sat with that.

Finally, his father asked, "Is he old enough?"

His mother didn't answer right away. She looked at the empty space on the table, the place where forms sometimes sat. Where names sometimes got written down.

"He's old enough to refuse," she said. "That may be enough."

"And the girl?"

"We wait."

Not because it was safe.

Because it was right.

"If she asks," his father said.

“Then we answer,” his mother finished. “Until then, we watch.”

She stood and turned off the kitchen light, leaving the room in shadow.

Down the hall, Evan shifted in his chair, unaware of how carefully a future had just been left untouched.

No name was written down that night.

And because of that, she remained what she had been all along.

Unclaimed.

Uncorrected.

And, for now—

Free.